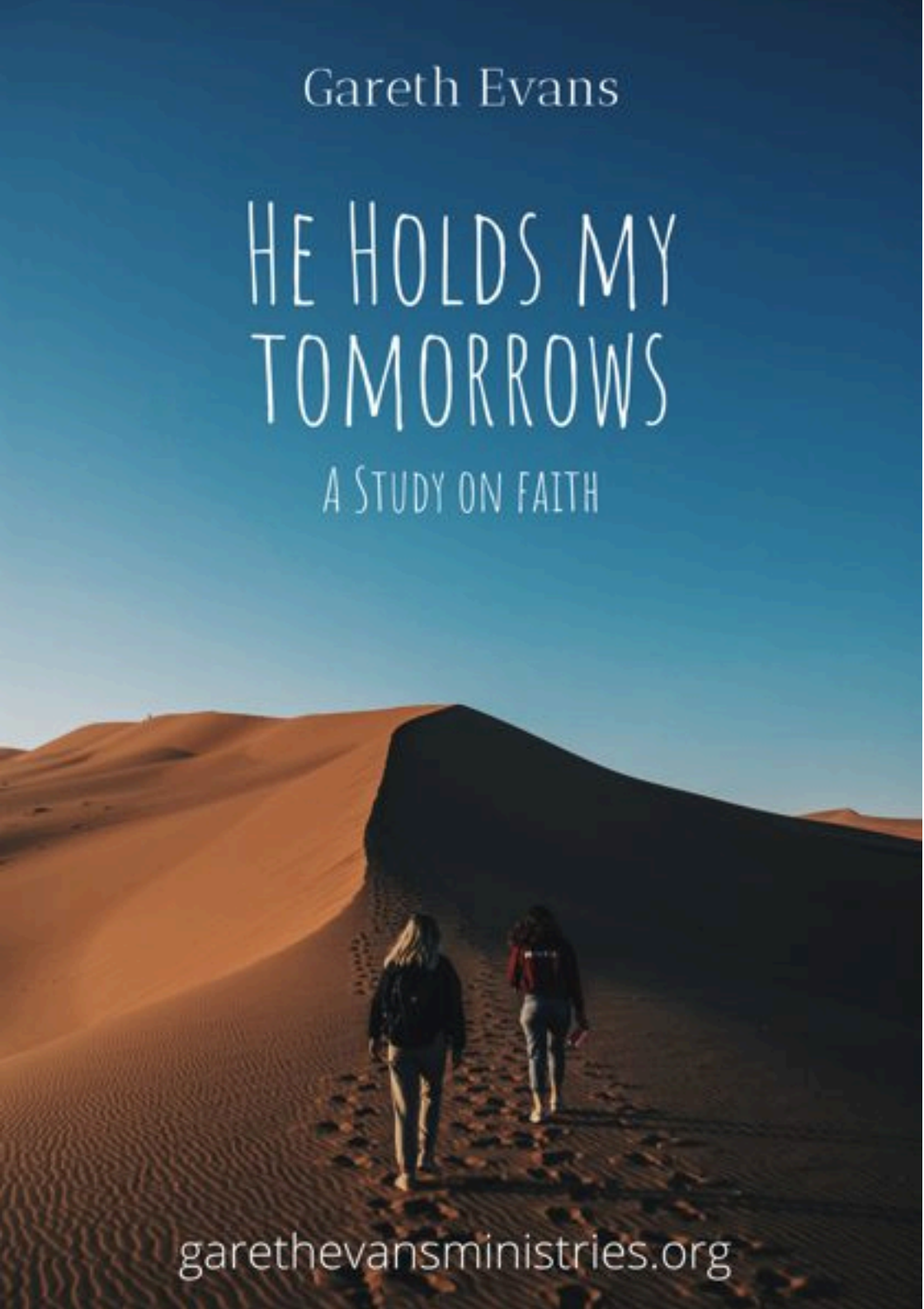


A photograph of two people walking away from the camera on a vast, orange sand dune under a clear blue sky. The person on the left has blonde hair and is wearing a dark jacket and light-colored pants. The person on the right is wearing a red jacket and blue jeans. Their footprints are visible in the sand. The dune's surface is covered in fine, wavy ripples. The sky is a gradient of blue, from a deeper blue at the top to a lighter blue near the horizon.

Gareth Evans

HE HOLDS MY TOMORROWS

A STUDY ON FAITH

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He Holds My Tomorrows

Gareth Evans

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Matthew 10:8

About the Author

Gareth Evans

1938–

Gareth Evans, born in 1938 in Merthyr Tydfil, is an itinerant pastor, teacher, and author. He studied physics, taught globally, authored devotionals, and now ministers to the hurting church through his website. Gareth, married to Anne, has three daughters, eight grand children, and fourteen great-grand children. His teachings emphasize practical faith and biblical wisdom. With a unique blend of scientific background and spiritual insight, Evans brings clarity to complex theological concepts.

Read the full biography at <https://ochorus.com/authors/gareth-evans/>

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Personal Profile

Gareth, and his wife Anne, were both born and raised in Wales. They married in 1961 after he received his Bachelor of Science with honors in Physics and a Diploma of Education from the University of Wales. In 1975, they immigrated to Canada where Gareth continued in his chosen profession as a secondary school physics teacher. In 1979, he was invited to pastor a church in Kitchener, Ontario with the Christian and Missionary Alliance.

Four years later, he received a call to Victoria, British Columbia where he pastored for the next eight years, and where they still reside.

In 1990, Gareth was invited to serve as the chaplain on board the Mercy Ship, M/V Anastasis, working between Europe and West Africa.

There he and Anne ministered to the crew and had many opportunities to speak at churches, pastors' seminars, and missionary conferences. Since leaving the ship in 1994, Gareth has traveled extensively, teaching at discipleship training schools and various conferences. Gareth and Anne have three daughters, nine grandchildren and ten great-grandchildren.

Controversy

Mary had been ill for some months with Epstein Barr Syndrome, commonly called “Yuppie flu,” or “the disease of the nineties.”

Her doctors had tried many medications to bring her back to the healthy young lady she had been a year before, but they were perplexed, as were all the medical professionals, by this disease which attacks the immune system, causing its victim to be very low in energy with continual weariness.

There was no known cure, and ignorance of its causes began to produce fear in many of Mary’s friends. Some associated it with AIDS, another scourge affecting the immune system. She had been very active in her church, but now she stayed away since no one was sure if this disease was contagious.

She read many books and watched television documentaries about the disease, even trying some of the experimental ‘cures’ recommended. Few friends came to visit her though some did telephone regularly to see how she was doing. They told her that the church was praying for her and that she should remain encouraged.

Since her teen years, Mary had been a believer in the Lord Jesus, having given her life to Him at a church service. Over the years her belief and trust had grown as she studied the Scriptures, prayed, and faithfully attended church services.

Through the trying months of her sickness, she had held on to her trust in the Lord, believing that “all things work together for good to those that

love the Lord” (Romans 8:28). Even though she did not understand, she would still trust Him.

Though she was not from my church, it was my practice to visit Mary a couple of times a month. We had become friends through another ministry in which we had been involved, so it concerned me to see her so weak in this dreadful disease. She would always be cheerful and grateful as I drove her to her bank or a store, something she couldn’t do for herself in that debilitating condition.

One day, however, when I arrived at her home, I found her greatly distressed. It took quite some time for her to compose herself enough to tell me what had happened. She had received a telephone call from one of her closest ‘friends’ at church, telling her that the prayer group had decided to stop praying for her recovery. The reason given was that, “she obviously did not have faith, or she would have been healed by now.”

The implication was that because she was ‘faithless’ they could no longer consider her a part of their family!

What a terrible misunderstanding of the nature of faith and how it operates in our lives! As I study Scripture, I see nothing that justifies the actions or beliefs of that church prayer group.

To them, evidently, faith was something one could whip up by one’s own effort or diligence. If Mary had been able to create enough of this mysterious ‘essence’ called faith, God would have been compelled to meet her need of healing! Essentially, they believed that faith is quantitative and a sufficient measure pleases God; therefore, she only needed to believe more!

I believe in divine healing as one of the riches afforded us in the victory of the cross, but have discovered that there is no formula to obtain it. God is still sovereign in granting healing and good health, and no amount of believing, hours praying, or buckets of tears measure up to His sovereign grace.

Like the father of the demonic child whose story is recorded in Mark 9, Mary cried out “Lord, I believe; help my unbelief!”

In that story, the disciples had believed that they could heal the boy, but they had failed. Jesus pointed out to them that it was faith they needed, not belief. One could add, “even the devils believe!”

Belief is NOT Faith Pastor John was worried! Just two years earlier he had seen the attendance at his small church grow rapidly as many new people came into fellowship. Whole families had been converted and there had been talk of revival. They had soon passed the two-hundred mark in regular attendance; financial offerings were up by more than 100% over previous years, and an excitement pervaded the sanctuary each week. It had been easy to preach and there were always volunteers to man the many ministries springing up in every department of the church.

“Pastor, we need to build a bigger sanctuary,” said his elders.

“God is obviously doing a major work in our community.” It had not been difficult to persuade the congregation to go along with this and soon plans were being made for a sanctuary that would hold over a thousand worshippers. Anyone who expressed apprehension over the grandiose plans was branded as ‘lacking faith.’ Indeed, as God was evidently in this, greater faith ought to be exercised. So, the plans escalated until a building was planned that would ultimately cost over three million dollars!

What John had not planned for was a great increase in mortgage rates at the same time as a major employer pulled out of that small town, leaving many unemployed, several of whom were members of John’s church.

The interest payments soon became too large for the congregation, and the problem was compounded as people started to leave that fellowship rather than be in a church shackled with a large financial burden which was, in their opinion, not of their own making.

What had gone wrong? Had God failed them when they had exercised such great faith ? Or had John - and his elders - mistaken faith for presumption? Indeed, had they ever understood what faith is? To them, faith was sanctified risk taking with the unspoken rider that, if things don't work out, it must be God's fault.

In His temptations by Satan, recorded for us in Luke 4:1-13, Jesus clearly shows us the difference between faith and presumption.

Jesus had a real need; He was hungry after spending nearly six weeks in the wilderness. He had been led there by the Holy Spirit after His baptism in Jordan.

Though Scripture is silent, I believe it was there that He communed with His heavenly Father concerning the things that must happen to Him. He knew that His cup would be bitter. He also knew that He had a choice - His will or the Father's. After those days, Satan challenges Him with real temptation.

"If you are the Son of God, command this stone to become bread" (Luke 4:3).

If He had done so, His hunger would have been assuaged and He would have proved Himself to be more powerful than His adversary; surely that would have shown Him to be truly the Son of God. He knew He could do it! Why not name it and claim it? He could have, but that would not have been faith - it would have been presumption and would have been contrary to His Father's will.

In the third temptation, Satan even quotes Scripture to Jesus.

"You know that God will not allow you to be harmed. Even if You throw yourself down from the topmost point of the temple, no harm will come to you. The angels will bear you up. Imagine what the people will think if you should do that!

They will all flock to follow you, so you do not need to suffer and die on a cross” (Luke 4:9-11).

Jesus could have performed the miracle, claiming the promises of God’s Word, but it would not have been faith; it would have been presumption, again contrary to His Father’s will.

Presumption Is NOT Faith Like Satan, there are many believers who will quote the Scriptures as their grounds for ‘faith.’ For example, I heard James 3:2 being taught on my television just this past week.

“The letter of James declares that if a man can control his own tongue, he is able to bridle the whole body. Therefore, make sure you speak only positive things. If you do, you will never be sick!”

Such teachers justify their position with expressions of faith.

“The Bible says it, I believe it, that’s it!”

I am aware of major denominations who base their doctrines on such a misunderstanding of faith. They would group themselves under the generic title of “Word of Faith” churches, more cynically called by terms such as “Name it, claim it!” or “Blab it, grab it!” or “Confess it, possess it!” I seldom watch Christian TV but, when I do turn on my set on a Sunday morning, I will invariably find a station where such a message is being proclaimed.

I must confess that there is much good teaching in what they say. We need to be a people who can base our lives on the solid foundation of God’s Word, with its many wonderful promises and riches that are ours in Christ; However, we must be very careful to correctly exegete the Word, claiming only those promises which apply to us, and being obedient to the conditions for such promises where conditions apply.

To claim that nothing can separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus is the unconditional blessing for all believers. However, the promises of the Upper Room - peace which the world cannot give or take

away, a joy that is full - are conditional upon the covenant of the Upper Room. There the disciples covenanted to encourage and refresh one another (wash one another's feet), to obey His commandment, to love one another, and to be obedient to His Word.

I am convinced that there is another error in their understanding of faith. In reality, they should call themselves "Word of Hope" churches, as hope has far more to do with belief than faith does! It is hope that says, "God said it! I believe it! That's good enough for me!"

We speak so little about Christian hope because we have confused it with worldly hope. Whenever the world speaks of hope, there is a negative possibility associated. "I hope it will not rain tomorrow." (It may do so!) "I hope I pass my exams!"

(I may fail!) "I hope you will be happy in your marriage."

(There may be a divorce!) Christian hope has no such negative connotation. It is an eager expectation of what is certain! So, when we speak out the truths of God's Word, and when we claim its promises, we are expressing hope, not faith.

Hope is an attribute of the mind and is evidenced in confidence. Faith is an attribute of the heart and is evidenced in obedience.

Hope is NOT Faith Another aspect of the power of belief is seen in the area of positive thinking. The world understands that 'what you believe you are, you are,' so company executives regularly attend courses on positive thinking. "How to think yourself to success." Now, we have seminars for church leaders based on the same premises and practices.

Sadly, there are many churches, some very large with TV ministries, who would preach about faith but, in reality, teach positive thinking. In recent years, we have even introduced such New Age practices as 'visualization techniques' to produce healing from sickness, mistakenly equating the positive thinking of visualization to faith.

As strange as it may seem, there are many people today who will give you testimony that the Lord has done such a healing for them. They will claim it to be the result of faith - exercised in visualization.

I was actually present in the small group where they prayed this over a woman who had come forward for prayer: "Imagine the cancer within your body. Can you see it? Now imagine the hand of Jesus reaching into that sick place and pulling the cancerous cells out. He's doing it right now as you see Him!

Hallelujah! You are now healed!"

Positive Thinking is NOT Faith There are great controversies raised whenever men speak about faith. Just what is faith? What is a work of faith outlined in 1 Thessalonians 1:3 and further, what is the walk of faith mentioned in 2 Corinthians 5:7? Since, "it is impossible to please God without faith" (Hebrews 11:6), the desire of every believer should be to understand what faith is.

Paul declares several times that we are "justified by faith" (Ephesians 2:8-9 and Romans), and James argues that "faith without works is dead" (James 2:17). Some who side with Paul (or rather, their interpretation of Paul), consider that James has no place in Holy Writ! Martin Luther, a great instrument of reformation, declared that the book of James is "a book of straw," and should not be in the Scriptures! Others would side with James (or their interpretation of James), classifying all Pauline believers with derogatory terms such as "fundamentalists."

Even the words of Jesus enter the controversy!

To Nicodemus He said those wonderful words, "For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son that whosoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life" (John 3:16). However, when He commissioned His disciples to go into all the world to preach the good

news, He added, “He who believes and is baptized shall be saved” (Mark 16:16).

Paul adds further confusion. “If you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus Christ and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you shall be saved” (Romans 10:9).

So, are we justified by faith? If so, is faith believing? Or is it trusting, maybe confessing, or perhaps being baptized? Or could it be something else?

Even the translators of the King James Version showed their confusion when, in Hebrews 10:23, they wrote, “Let us hold fast the profession of our faith,” translating the Greek word ‘elpis’ as ‘faith’ when it is translated as ‘hope’ in every other context. Indeed, it seems to me that faith and hope are regularly confused by the average believer! Hope has far more to do with belief than faith does!

Let me repeat, hope is an attribute of the mind and is evidenced in confidence, whereas faith is an attribute of the heart and is evidenced in obedience.

Three Kinds of Faith

When I study Scripture, I find three kinds of faith: saving faith, fruit of faith, the gift of faith.

Saving Faith “For by grace are you saved through faith; and this is not your own doing, it is the gift of God - not because of works lest any man should boast” (Ephesians 2:8-9).

This is the experience of all those who have been born again - born of the Spirit. We acknowledge that we are sinners without any hope in this world and desperately needy of God’s intervention in our lives. We are walking in darkness, unrighteous, and strangers to His promises and blessings.

If it were not for the fact that God has come into our human situation and revealed His love to us through the death of His Son on the cross, we would still be dead in our sins and most miserable; however, the righteousness of God has been revealed to us, “the righteousness of God through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe” (Romans 3:22).

Paul declares that God justifies all who have faith in Jesus (Romans 3:26). What a lovely word that is! Justified - just as if I’d never sinned! That is how God now looks at us. He sees us ‘in His Son’ and not in our sin. It was firstly His grace in operation. He showed us favor that was not deserved.

Indeed, one of the many definitions of grace is “unmerited favor;” however, the definition that I like the best is this mnemonic: G od’s R iches A t

Christ's Expense He paid the price that I might receive all the blessings of this wonderful Christian life.

While on the topic of grace, have you ever considered the difference between grace and mercy? Let me present this distinction for your blessing: Grace is God treating me as I do not deserve, whereas mercy is God not treating me as I do deserve!

This gift of grace from God has to be received by faith, which I have called saving faith ; however, even this is a gift from God. I cannot believe with faith unless God gives me the ability to do so!

There is no source of faith in me. I may make a choice to believe, and I may want to believe, but the ability to exercise saving faith is beyond me. I can believe in my head, but I need to believe in my heart, since it differentiates between those who have been justified and those still in their sins.

For two years I had the privilege of teaching in a Jewish Academy. My position was the Head of the Science Department but, near the end of my time at that school, I was invited to speak to the senior class concerning the Christian faith. The teacher in charge of that class told me that they were studying Comparative Religion and that "today's subject is Christianity!" Just one lesson to study what many spend all their lifetime doing – and still not understanding!

The following morning, I was asked to call on the senior rabbi, a meeting I did not relish as he had not been party to the original invitation for me to speak to the students.

He welcomed me warmly, which set me at ease, and then told me of his experience with the same students that morning. "I have never seen them so animated and so eager to talk about God," he said. "They were amazed to find a scientist who is also a man of faith."

How sad it is that so many people have this delusion. It is my experience that a relatively high proportion of scientists are also men of great faith.

Indeed, many would say that they believe in God because, as scientists, they have to ask real questions about life, and they find the only answers in believing!

The rabbi continued, “What saddens me is that my students only believe in God in their heads, and I do not know how to get it into their hearts!”

I told him that there was only one way, that of acknowledging that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, Messiah. He said that we would have to agree to disagree, but the point was made.

(For a more complete account of that wonderful time in the Hebrew Academy, where I was given much freedom to share my convictions about Christ, read my other book “Stepping Stones.”)

It is my sad conviction, after many years as a pastor, that many people in our congregations are no different from those Jewish students. They have head knowledge, but no experience of the living Christ. They hope (in the worldly sense, with its negative possibilities), but know nothing of “Christ in you, the hope of glory” (Colossians 1:27). Indeed, to so many, the word ‘experience’ conjures up visions of emotionalism and wayward Charismatics and they are determined to safeguard themselves from such excesses.

It was the ‘beloved’ apostle John who wrote, “These things I have written unto you that believe (with the head?) on the name of the Son of God; that you may know (with inner certainty?) that you have eternal life, and that you may believe (with the heart?) on the name of the son of God” (1 John 5:13).

Throughout his letter he is constantly reaffirming the experiencing of our faith. He writes about fellowshiping with the Father and knowing that we know Him. We know it because we experience His love and His Spirit, bearing witness with our spirits that we are the sons of God.

Saving Faith , a gift from God, enables us to touch the divine, and open a channel so that life may flow into our souls. The Holy Spirit imparts life, and we are born again. We are baptized by the Spirit into the Body of Christ and become one with all others in that Body (1 Corinthians 12:13). Our believing with the head becomes a knowing of the heart; however, we are but babes in the faith and we need to grow.

Again, it is my sad belief that a large proportion of born-again believers do not progress far from this starting point. They still need to be taught principles of God's Word. They need milk, not solid food. They are unskilled in the word of righteousness, for they are still children (Hebrews 5:11-14).

In John's first letter, the aged apostle sets out on - what I believe is - a measuring rod for Christian maturity. He likens his readers to children, young men, and fathers (1 John 2:13-14). It is interesting how he addresses each of these three, for he is not writing to those who fit chronologically into the groups, but spiritually. I have met some young men and women whom John would describe as fathers and mothers in faith. Sadly, on the contrary, I have met many, much older believers, having been in the church for several years, but have never progressed beyond being immature children.

Jesus did say that unless we become as little children we cannot enter the kingdom of Heaven, but when we have entered through the new birth (John 3:3-36), He expects us to grow into maturity. I am amazed how childish so many Christians are in their immaturity.

Little children have had their sins forgiven and have a relationship with the Father. They can pray and enjoy the blessings of fellowship, but display little evidence of Christian growth. Such a person may be of any age chronologically, but remains childish spiritually. They have saving faith , but nothing more.

A young man is one who “has overcome the evil one, being strong as the word of God abides in him” (1 John 2:14). They are active in the battle for righteousness; walking in victory, and getting to know God in more of His attributes.

Many believers are not aware that there is a battle going on, and they live their lives in ignorance of Satan’s tactics which rob them of the joys and victories that should be theirs. Others know there is a war but consider the antagonists as being God (or Jesus) and Satan. Let us be clear about this - there is no war going on today between Jesus and Satan - that battle was fought on the cross 2000 years ago and Jesus won!

“He spoiled principalities and powers, and made a show of them openly, triumphing over them in it” (Colossians 2:15).

The battle today is between Satan and us . Does that frighten you? It shouldn’t when you realize his tactics and know that the Lord expects you to win because “greater is He that is in you than he that is in the world” (1 John 4:4).

Paul could rightly say , “I am not ignorant of his tactics” (2 Corinthians 2:11). How many of us can say the same? The young man can, “for he is strong, and the Word of God abides in him” (1 John 2:14).

A father is one who is mature, having passed through the other two stages. He has come to “know Him who is from the beginning” (1 John 2:14). He knows the eternal One. Surely this should be our goal, “To know Him and to make Him known” (John 17:2 and Matthew 28:19-20).

I am reminded of Moses who was known as God’s friend. He talked with God on Mount Sinai and in the tabernacle, so that his face shone, and the people could not bear to look upon its shining. He knew God intimately; however, tasting of divine things only produces desire to taste more, and so the prophet makes a request of God, his friend.

“O Lord,” he cries, “please show me your glory!” (Exodus 33).

God says that He cannot reveal His glory for that would surely cause the death of Moses; however, He adds a striking comment.

“‘Moses,’ said the Lord, ‘I know your name , so I am going to reveal to you My name ,’” and He proceeds to declare Himself as a God of mercy and grace, longsuffering, and abundant in goodness and truth (Exodus 3:13-15). In biblical days, one’s name spoke of their character, as will be seen if you make a study of biblical names.

God is saying that He knows the character of Moses, and therefore is willing to reveal His own character.

Do you want to know more of God, He who is from the beginning, the Eternal One? He wants to make Himself known to you, and He knows your name !

How can He make His character known if your name is ‘unfaithful one’, ‘hypocrite’, ‘doubter’, ‘proud one’, ‘weak one’, ‘deceiver’, or ‘childish’?

He waits until you will grow into maturity as the young man whose name is ‘strong one’, ‘overcomer’, ‘faithful one’, and ‘man of integrity’; then makes more of Himself known, so you can continue in maturing to the stature of a father or mother of the faith.

Thank God for His wonderful gift of saving faith , but we must go on into maturity of faith.

Fruit of Faith “But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law” (Galatians 5:22-23).

When we bought our first home in Canada, we were delighted that there were several fruit trees in the garden. There was an apple tree, two plum trees and two cherry trees; however, we were to be disappointed when the summer came as the fruit was poor. I decided to prune the trees, so with a saw in hand, I performed the operation. I knew little about pruning trees except that it is essential to open up the center of the tree to the sun, and to

remove all wasteful suckers that would drain the life-giving nutrients from the fruit-bearing branches.

My friends said that, in my ignorance of the correct pruning technique, I had cut away too much material and the trees would now surely die. The following summer we watched in amazement as each of the trees bore so much quality fruit that they were weighted down to the ground.

I remember the evening well that Anne and I sat out on our garden swing, enjoying the balmy Ontario weather. We heard a strange noise, quickly followed by other similar noises. It was like a long groan with a sudden “aahhh...” of relief. We looked around to see if someone was in pain near us. Imagine our surprise when we realized the sound was coming from our fruit trees! Then we saw the reason for the groaning.

One of the branches on our apple tree was swelling and the groan showed the effort of the tree as it grew. Suddenly there was the sound of relief as the swelling burst and an apple popped out to take its place among all the other beautiful fruit on the branch! Our cherry and plum trees were behaving the same way, though their groaning was of a different sound.

Evidently, the trees were trying so hard to please us by producing the best fruit that they could!

Of course, none of you would believe that story. It is foolish to think that a tree can bring forth fruit by its own effort! Yet, that is exactly what so many believers think when it comes to having the fruit of the Spirit in their lives! Somehow, we cannot have the fruit of faith unless we work very hard to produce it, and by becoming more spiritual!

The Psalmist David understood how spiritual fruit is produced and wrote in Psalm 1:3 that “the righteous [person] is like a tree planted by streams of water, that yields its fruit in its season.”

All the tree does is stand there! It opens its branches to the sun, drinks in the rain, and draws its sap from the watered ground beneath. Then the

nature of the life within the tree produces the appropriate fruit. In the same way, spiritual fruit is produced.

As we abide in the vine - which is Jesus - our hearts are opened to the 'shining face' of God and we draw from the wells of the Spirit of God. Then fruit - characteristics of the new life within us - are produced in season. This doesn't happen overnight. It takes time to mature as a Christian, it takes willingness to be pruned, it takes standing upon the promises of God's Word, and it takes consistent trust. It doesn't take effort!

Many believers see themselves like trees, but they spend much time examining themselves for evidence of fruit. Instead of looking out along the 'branches' to see if fruit is evident, we would be better occupied in turning our eyes in toward the trunk of the tree, the source of all the nourishment that the branches receive. We would be better to turn our eyes upon Jesus, the true vine into which we have been grafted. Then the fruit would grow, and others would see it in its season.

It is He who produces the fruit of faith in all who abide in Him and, like the tree of Psalm 1, draw from the streams of Holy Spirit water.

Let us understand something more about all the fruit of the Spirit. We so easily associate them with characteristics found in all people, but they are only available to those who have been born again of the Spirit. It is He who produces them in us, and the non-Christian cannot know anything about them!

"The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned" (1 Corinthians 2:14).

Thus, it is that patience for example, has little to do with patiently waiting for the traffic lights to change! Many non-believers have far more patience than believers! The world cannot know anything about the love that is shed abroad in the believer's heart, the joy that abides when all around us

is going wrong, the peace in the midst of the storm. They are fruit of the indwelling Spirit, and riches only for the child of God.

Similarly, the fruit of faith will only be evidenced in the life of the maturing believer.

As I study these nine fruits, I have come to the opinion that they grow more exotic or rare as I read along. Every new believer has had some taste of love, joy and peace. Truly, from the moment of the new birth, many can give testimony that, “heaven above is softer blue, earth around is sweeter green; something lives in every hue that Christless eyes have never seen” (G Wade Robinson).

Then, as time goes on, the initial joy and peace seem to go as the Father begins the process of disciplining us to conform us to the image of His Son; however, as we abide in Him, the fruit returns in a richer, fuller experience. We initially experienced His love overwhelming us, but now we find it reaching through us to others. His joy first came as a new song in our hearts making life seem like a new day, but now we begin to find that song welling up within us even in the darkest of nights.

At first, His peace stilled the storms that were raging in our hearts, but now His peace is a deep security in the midst of life’s storms.

In the maturing believer, we begin to see more of the character of Jesus in bearing the ridicule of the world. Our patience replaces the rebellious nature of the old man that once we were, and we find we do not react to trying situations as before.

It has been said that if you want to see the gentleness of Jesus, look at His actions; if you want to see His goodness, look at His attitudes. So it is that, as we grow in the fruit of the Spirit, we mature in both our actions and our attitudes.

Then the life of faith becomes evident as the believer begins to walk in obedience to the promptings of the Spirit, seeing the hand of the Lord lead-

ing and guiding him. The meek man is one who has laid down his own rights and submitted himself fully to the Lord's will. He is malleable and teachable; moldable into a vessel fit for the use of the king.

Finally, the rarest of the fruit is able to come. This is the fruit that the apostle Paul longed for: self-control . This is the 'putting to death' of which he wrote in Romans 7:15-24. He recognized how impossible it would be for him to produce this mastery over self if it were not for the fact that, through the work of the cross, there is such a victory possible.

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus. For the law of the Spirit of life has set you free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death" (Romans 8:1-2).

Such fruit only comes from the Holy Spirit within the believer and the same is true of faith . Only He can produce it; no effort of mine will avail!

I'd like to pose an additional thought on the fruit of the Spirit.

The word "fruit" is singular. These are not many different fruits growing independently of one another, but one fruit evidenced in different ways. It has been suggested that the first three (love, joy, and peace), are an inner experience of the Holy Spirit abiding in the believer, whereas the second triplet (patience, gentleness, goodness) are an outward expression as we relate to mankind around us, and the last triplet (faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control) are to do with our union with God.

Gift of Faith "To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good... to another faith by the same Spirit..." (1 Corinthians 12: 7, 9).

The third kind of faith that I find in the Bible is called the gift of faith . The apostle Paul is writing to the church at Corinth about the "charismata", (which translates as "grace gifts" from the Greek) given by the Holy Spirit to the church. There are many such gifts listed for us in

Romans 12 and 1 Corinthians 12, together with the ministry gifts named in Ephesians 4:11.

The gifts are given to individuals, not that they might glory or boast in them, but that they might be for the benefit of all. In truth, the gifts are given to the church, and individuals are only the instruments that the Spirit would use. It is striking that in all three references mentioned, Paul also emphasizes the unity of the Body of Christ. The purpose of all the gifts is to enable the church to grow in unity so that it might succeed in its ministry of bringing men and women to the Lord.

How then is the gift of faith evidenced in operation?

Imagine this scenario in the Board of Elders meeting of a local church. A proposal has just been made to start an extension work in the neighborhood to try to reach the unchurched youth of the community. It is acknowledged that this is the only evangelical church in the area and there is an increasing number of young people, unemployed and in need, forming companionship gangs.

Many church members have expressed their emotions, ranging from compassion to fear, so the proposal has been made.

Neither the pastor nor any of the elders have the energy or the ability to work with these young adults so it is recognized that a new youth worker needs to be employed. “But how shall we pay him and finance this ministry?”

The question is sincere as the church has been struggling financially in recent years. The simple answer, and there is always someone who will give it, is that ‘we must pray more, and God will supply.’ That is true so long as it is God’s purpose to start the work and employ the youth worker. But how do we know if this is His purpose? It sounds good, but there are many programs that sound good to us but never seem to receive God’s blessing.

The elders decide to wait on the matter, to pray and to come together one week later to make the decision.

As they enter the Board Room, imagine you are an invisible witness who can read the thoughts on each man's mind. "One for, one against... two for, three for, two against... four for, four against... and the pastor..." How can they possibly come to any agreement while the young people on the streets are continuing in their lostness?!

The men start with prayer and then begin to share their thoughts. Suddenly, one man, who had entered as an 'against', speaks up. "When I came in here tonight, I was of the opinion that this is not the time to start a new work; however, as I have listened to the arguments for and against, something has happened within me and I have changed my position! I know that the Lord is in this! I vote that we should appoint a new youth worker!" Others begin to speak, and, within just a few minutes, an unanimous decision is reached. What happened?

Not only did each man hear what the others were saying but, because they were men genuinely seeking God's will, they heard Him speak in their spirits. He planted within each of them faith to believe. That is the gift of faith.

Though the financial difficulties were real, He gave them faith that overcame the circumstances. It may only have been a 'grain of mustard seed' (Mark 4:30-32), but because it was planted in their spirits by God Himself, their mountain would be removed. Such faith is always rewarded by the blessing of God. Such faith always removes mountains!

I have seen the gift of faith in operation several times. I have seen people doing great things for God when all around them thought it impossible. They stopped looking at the circumstances because they knew His prompting.

I had a dear friend named Yorrie Richards who once stammered so badly that it was impossible for him to say a simple sentence. He came to know the Lord when facing a court trial for theft. The trial judge warned him that “the path you have chosen to follow may well end at the gallows”. All the town knew of his background in crime, and many were cynical about his conversion.

Some time later, Yorrie and I met up again and he suggested to me the most impossible thing. He wanted to book the main hall in his home town and to preach the gospel to all those who had known him in his youth and had been so unbelieving. I advised him against such a venture as it would surely cause us much embarrassment and could hardly do any good for the gospel. He insisted that the Lord had laid this on his heart, and he believed it to be His leading.

We booked the hall and advertised the meeting. I stood aside after the introductions and Yorrie faced his audience. He immediately began to stutter, and I felt embarrassed for him. I could hardly bring myself to listen.

Then a strange quietness fell over the room as Yorrie’s voice became more controlled and he began to speak with authority and confidence, telling what the Lord had done. There were many tears shed that night as God worked a miracle among us, because one of his ‘weak and foolish’ ones had responded to His gift of faith. Many thousands throughout Britain and Canada can give testimony today of the anointed preaching of Yorrie Richards.

Thus, I present to you the three kinds of faith: saving faith , the fruit of faith , and the gift of faith .

What immediately strikes me is that all three find their source in God, not in the believer! There is nothing I can do to produce faith in me, so please don’t tell me to ‘have more faith’ when you see me sick or struggling in my Christian walk. What I need to develop is more trust, not faith.

Walking by Faith

If you were to choose some Biblical characters to demonstrate what it is to walk by faith, whom would you select?

Caleb, who, though more than eighty years old, wanted to fight giants?
Elisha, who stood against all the prophets of Baal?

Daniel, who publicly prayed knowing that it might cost him his life?
But it is interesting to see those whom the Bible notes as examples of faith.

None of the above!

The apostle Paul writes about faith in his letter to the Romans declaring, “for we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law” (Romans 3:28). He then takes all of chapter four to give his example of the patriarch Abraham, to whom ‘faith was reckoned for righteousness.’

The apostle James also takes Abraham as his supreme example of the life of faith, declaring that faith without works is dead.

He asks, “was not Abraham our father justified by works, when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar? You see that faith was active along with works, and faith was completed by his works” (James 2:21-22).

However, James adds a second example, one which must seem strange to all of us. He presents to us Rahab the harlot, who welcomed the spies sent into Jericho. By all human standards she was hardly a commendable person; besides following a despicable trade, she was a traitor and a liar who cared only for her own safety. Yet she is named as an example of faith.

What is even more surprising is that James is not the only one who so considers her! The author of Hebrews also names her in their extensive list. In my former understanding of faith, I would certainly not have considered her, nor many others mentioned in Hebrews 11! Then, maybe it's my understanding of faith that has to change.

Some would even title Hebrews 11 as "Heroes of Faith." I see no heroes there. Just ordinary people like you and I who experienced all kinds of circumstances in the walk of faith.

Some conquered kingdoms by faith, whereas others were put to death by faith! A better title for the chapter would be "Examples of Faith," as its purpose is to show us that, in His sovereignty, God leads men and women along many different paths in order to fulfill His will in and through them.

To us, torture and death do not seem compatible to God's will for the believer, but history is replete with stories of how the church grew rapidly upon the blood of martyrs. It was God's will that they died, so that they might be 'to the praise of His glory.' This is not to say that He does not have compassion for the feelings of people.

Of course, He does, but, among His saints, He is developing those who, by their suffering and death, will bring greater glory to Him than by their life. To them, He has guaranteed a 'better Resurrection.'

"Sometimes on the mount where the sun shines so bright, God leads His dear children along.

Sometimes in the valley, in the darkest of nights, God leads His dear children along.

Some through the water, some through the flood, Some through the fire, but all through the blood.

Some through great sorrow, but God gives a song, In the night season and all the day long" (G.A Young).

In the Gospels we read of only six people whom Jesus commended for their faith. If the choices of Paul, James and the author of Hebrews raise your eyebrows, wait till you see those whom Jesus chooses!

At least three of them were not even Jews, one was a leper, another had been sick for many years, one was blind, three declared themselves ‘unworthy’ and all were sinners.

The Roman Centurion → Matthew 8:5-13 His servant was lying paralyzed at home so he asked the Lord if he would heal him.

“I’ll come with you,” said the Master, but the centurion answered him, “Lord, I am not worthy for you to come under my roof, but just speak the word and my servant will be healed!”

Let us understand this; he probably had the finest house in the city, for the rank of a centurion in the Roman army was one of great honor. His unworthiness was not because of his status, but because he realized he was in the presence of someone far greater than himself. He continued, “Lord, I am like you, a man under authority.”

Under what authority did he consider Jesus to be? He had no delegated authority from the Jewish authorities, nor did he have the status of one schooled at the feet of a great rabbi. He was a lowly carpenter, but He did have the authority of the anointing of God, and the centurion recognized this. How? By faith!

Jesus marveled and said, “I have never found such faith in all of Israel!”

Where was the faith? The centurion had an inner witness that this man, Jesus, was a man with divine authority. He obeyed that witness (of the Holy Spirit) and submitted himself to that authority.

““Lord, I am not worthy to have you come under my roof, but only say the word, and my servant will be healed”” (Matthew 8:8).

The Woman With A Hemorrhage → Mark 5:25-34 This unfortunate woman had endured much at the hands of many physicians with no healing

from her embarrassing and distressing condition. Indeed, she was getting much worse.

The law declared her ‘unclean’ so she was not allowed to enjoy many of the privileges of the common folk. She could not attend the celebrations of Feast Days, nor enter the synagogue to worship, and most of all, she must not come near the ‘righteous’ Pharisees and ‘holy men.’

She had heard of Jesus, but an inner witness told her to reach out to touch the hem of His garment. This was contrary to everything that she had been taught, but she obeyed and was healed. There was no precedent for this. She did not believe because she had heard of others being healed the same way.

She simply obeyed an inner impulse.

“And He said to her, ‘Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace, and be healed of your disease’” (Mark 5:34).

The Canaanite Woman → Matthew 15:22-28 This woman’s heart was breaking as she sought help for her demon-possessed daughter. She came to the Lord, but even He seemed to shun her and His disciples tried to drive her away.

She was not a Jew, but she saw what almost no one else had seen, even the disciples up to this time. She recognized Jesus as the Lord, the Son of David. These were terms well known to apply to the coming Messiah. Others had not yet recognized Him, but this Canaanite woman had. Such revelation only comes by the inner witness of the Holy Spirit. This same revelation came to Peter on Mount Hermon nearly two years later!

Jesus tested her understanding, her revelation, by challenging her that it was not good to throw the children’s bread (healing for the Jews) to the dogs (Gentiles). Her reply shows that she fully understood, by revelation, that He truly was the Messiah.

“Then Jesus answered her, ‘O woman, great is your faith! Be it done for you as you desire.’ And her daughter was healed instantly” (Matthew 15:28).

Blind Bartimaeus → Mark 10:46-52 Though blind, Bartimaeus could see more than all the great multitude of sighted people surrounding Jesus. He lived in the cursed city of Jericho and had lost his sight, becoming a beggar, despised by all around him. When he cried out the people sternly told him to be quiet, but he would not cease in his crying, for like the Canaanite woman, he had received a revelation, an inner witness of Jesus as Messiah. “He cried out... ‘Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me’” (Mark 10:48).

Jesus called the beggar to Him and asked a strange question, “What do you want me to do for you?” Bartimaeus replied, “Master, I want to regain my sight!” And Jesus said, “Go your way, your faith has made you well,” and immediately he regained his sight (Mark 10:51-52).

Revelation had preceded confession with healing as a result.

The Woman in Simon’s House → Luke 7:37-50 In John 11:2 and Matthew 26:6 it is said that this woman was Mary, sister of Lazarus. Simon, a Pharisee, watched her actions and began to judge Jesus as lacking discernment, for she was recognized as a sinner. Jesus, however, was fully aware of who she was, but recognized her actions as anointing him for burial. She probably had little understanding of this but, acting in obedience to an inner witness, the prompting of the Holy Spirit, and motivated by love, she had ministered to the Lord prophetically.

“[Jesus] said to the woman, ‘Your faith has saved you; go in peace’” (Luke 7:50).

The Tenth Leper → Luke 17:11-19 Ten lepers had come to Jesus seeking to be healed. All obeyed His instructions to go to the priests, to be declared ‘clean.’ This was a requirement of the Old Testament and, though one of them was a Samaritan, he also obeyed. On the way to the priests, all

of them were healed, but only the Samaritan acknowledged that his healing was not some magic trick, but was due to God so, falling at the feet of Jesus, he began to glorify God. He had obeyed the audible voice of the Son of God and had been healed.

“[Jesus] said to him, ‘Rise and go your way; your faith has made you well’” (Luke 17:19).

In all six examples, faith was evidenced and fulfilled in obedience . If there had been no obedience to the recognition of authority, to the revelation of deity, to the inner witness of the prompting of the Spirit, to the spoken word of the Lord, there would have been no miracles recorded.

Definition of Faith How then shall we define faith so that it meets all the questions of controversy and explains the choices of Jesus, Paul, James, and the writer to the Hebrews?

When I ask people to define faith the usual answer is to quote Hebrews 11:1, “Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen,” yet, when asked to explain their definition, I find few who have a convincing explanation.

To me, the author is simply saying what the apostle Paul has said elsewhere, as quoted in the previous chapter.

What is it that we hope for? Barclay, the author of the popular devotional series, *Our Daily Bread*, defines hope as “eager expectation for that which is promised.” The apostles Paul and Peter both gave testimony before their accusers of our great hope of Resurrection. To them, our hope is sure. To the author of Hebrews, it is as an anchor fixed within the veil of the presence of God. We hope for what we shall surely receive.

What shall we receive, except that which flows from the grace of God; that which He has promised? His gift of salvation, His gift of the Holy Spirit dwelling within us; His gifts given by the Holy Spirit: His gift .

I picture the little child at Christmas time or a birthday. They know they will receive something special from their parents - a gift from their love. He eagerly waits for the big day. They have hope for that which is surely going to come. Finally, they receive what had been promised: their gift. This is the substance of that which he hoped for. Their expectation has become reality.

Faith is the substance of things hoped for; it is a gift .

When I first arrived in Canada, I viewed the trees in our garden with great anticipation of enjoying their fruit the following spring; however, I had no knowledge of what kind of trees they were. I am not a scholar in horticulture, and could not recognise the trees by their leaves or shape. When the fruit began to arrive, however, I had no doubt what each one was. I knew them by their fruit . The fruit was the evidence I needed.

The nature of the trees had not changed, the character of the trees had not changed, but these had been hidden from my understanding, until the fruit came. The evidence of things unseen was the fruit upon the branches.

Similarly, the evidence of the Spirit-filled life is in its fruit.

Jesus said, “Either make the tree good and its fruit good, or make the tree bad and its fruit bad, for the tree is known by its fruit” (Matthew 12:33) Faith is the evidence of things unseen. It is a fruit .

The author of Hebrews 11 is saying no more than Paul said in 1 Corinthians 12:9 and Galatians 5:22.

I define faith as God’s finger in the hearts of men and women, moving them to do His will.

It is evidenced in obedience as an attitude of the heart. It is not an attitude of the mind. It is belief and response . The moving finger is God’s, the response of obedience is ours. The first and greatest work of faith a man can do is to believe in the Lord Jesus Christ unto salvation. Revelation precedes confession (see Peter on Mt. Hermon). It is evidenced in repentance , bap-

tism , confession and good deeds (works of righteousness). Where these are not evident, one can rightly doubt (like James) the reality of faith; it is effectively 'dead' (James 2:26).

The walk of faith is a daily submission to His will (revealed and unrevealed). Holding onto Daddy's hand! As Peter said, "To whom else can we go?" (John 6:68). As we hold on, our Father is able to move mountains! This is because of His character, not because of our strength of mind or belief! Note that even the devils believe in all that our Father can do, but that isn't considered faith (James 2:19).

Hearing God's Voice

While hearing God's voice is easy for some, for others it is a sense that must be strengthened!

It was a strange sight that caught the eye of Moses as he shepherded his father-in-law's sheep. A bush was burning fiercely but was not being consumed! The leaves remained green, though the flames licked about them (Exodus 3:2). He had never seen anything like this wonder in all his time in Egypt as Pharaoh's son, nor in the many years in which he had lived as a shepherd in the land of Midian. He stepped a little closer to investigate.

Suddenly a voice rang out, "Moses!"

Can you imagine his surprise, especially when it appeared that the voice was coming from the interior of the burning bush!?

The voice continued, "Take your shoes off your feet for you are standing on holy ground!" (Exodus 3:5). I'm sure he was quick to obey due to the nature of the event - he must have been afraid!

Thus began the long period of communion between God and Moses. Thereafter they spoke together often, as the Lord directed His servant in leading the Israelites out of their bondage in Egypt, gave instructions for the building of the tabernacle, and dictated several laws for His covenant people.

Indeed, we read that they spoke "face to face as a man speaks with his friend" (Exodus 33:11). No wonder Moses' face shone!

Don't you envy Moses being able to talk with God in that way?

I certainly do.

One can speculate on what it was that Moses saw, and heard when God spoke to him. What did God's voice sound like?

Was it a deep, resonating baritone as a trained Shakespearean actor?

Did it have a lilt or an accent? (Welsh maybe, like mine, seeing that He evidently enjoys visiting my country periodically, in great outpourings of revival?!) What language did He speak - that of Egypt where Moses was educated or that of the Midianites where Moses had lived for the past forty years?

All we can say for certain is that it was a language that Moses understood.

Was it the voice of a man or did it sound like 'rushing waters' as Ezekiel described the voice of the Almighty (Ezekiel 43:2)?

Elijah the prophet heard Him speak with a still, small voice, while Isaiah recorded that He spoke in his ear (1 Kings 19:12 and Isaiah 50:5).

Surely, it must be easy to walk in God's will when He speaks to you in an audible voice, just as He did to Moses and others of Old Testament days. It would be easy to walk the walk of faith in those circumstances!

Would It?

Maybe God would then demand much more of us if we could hear His voice clearly. We would have no excuse to disobey, and our obedience would not be faith. Slaves obey their masters, but it is often out of fear. That is not the kind of obedience that the Lord requires.

He is looking for a people who are tuned to hear His voice in the spirit and whose very nature has become obedience.

Not an obedience due to fear, but an obedience due to character. It has never been in His nature to compel or manipulate His people into doing His will or to walk according to His purposes. He has always given them the freedom to respond in love and willing obedience. The faith that pleases

God is not evidenced in the obedience of fear, but in the obedience of love and willingness.

Young Tommy was restless at the supper table as he wanted to go back outside to his waiting friends. “You cannot leave the table until you have finished your meal,” his mother said.

Tommy gulped at his food. “And sit down on your chair while you eat,” added his father. Tommy was slow to respond, so his father repeated the instructions in a voice, a little slower and a little louder. Still Tommy slouched by his chair, his eyes straining to watch his friends out of the window, as he crammed another fork full of spaghetti into his mouth.

His father’s voice grew sterner, and he spoke deliberately. “I have told you to sit down when you eat! Do as I say now !”

Tommy sat down, a sullen look on his tomato-stained face. His mouth was full so he could not speak, but inside his head a voice shouted out, “I may be sitting down on the outside, but I’m standing up on the inside!” Hardly an attitude of obedience that would please the father!

The Still, Small Voice The prophet Elijah had seen God do a mighty miracle before all the prophets of Baal. He was bold in slaying all these false leaders and the “hand of the Lord was upon him” (1 Kings 18:46). However, when he heard that Jezebel, the wicked queen, was seeking to take his life, he fled into the desert to hide and mourn. “I’ve had enough, Lord,” he cried. “Take away my life!” Hardly what one would expect from a ‘man of faith!’ First, an angel is sent to inquire why he is in this state, and then the Lord Himself speaks to Elijah - not in the great wind that tore apart the mountain, nor in the earthquake, or the fire, but in a still small voice. Surely, the first three would have caused him much fear and he would have responded quickly if God had spoken, but the still, small voice is unthreatening. He is ordered to return to Damascus and to anoint his succes-

sor, Elisha. Thus, Elijah regains his zeal for the Lord, for he has heard His voice. His obedience is that of faith.

I am reminded of ‘Thomas the doubter,’ the apostle who would not believe that the Lord had risen from the dead until he could see Him and put his fingers in the nail marks of the wounded hands. When Jesus appeared before him, Thomas finally believed and Jesus said to him, “Thomas, because you have seen me, you have believed: blessed are they who have not seen and yet have believed.”

He might as well have also said, “Blessed are those who have not heard the audible voice of God, and yet have obeyed!”

The walk and life of faith that pleases God is seen in the man or woman who, ‘have not heard’ (with the ear) and yet have obeyed.

Should we expect to hear the Lord’s voice? Of course we should! It was Jesus Himself who said that “the sheep hear My voice” (John 10:27).

When the Lord wants to communicate to us, to teach us His will, to direct us in His paths, He chooses not to do so with a loud voice, but by the still, small voice, heard only by the soul in tune with Him. He wants to speak to His sheep and most of them, I am sure, want to hear His voice.

Communication is always the responsibility of the communicator if the communicatee is willing to hear. That is why a good teacher will always seek to know if his students have understood what he has tried to teach.

So, is God speaking to us, His sheep? If so, why are we not hearing what He is saying?

Learning To Recognize His Voice I believe He speaks to me every day, but His voice is so often drowned out in the cacophony of other voices that rush through my head.

I need to learn the secret of which the Desert Fathers spoke and wrote, a mystery understood by those men and women of Church history, whose

lives have impressed us as being in deep communion with God; those called, often derisively, the mystics .

The Desert Fathers (and mothers) were the men and women of the 4th Century. A time when Christianity had become accepted by the Roman emperors and Christendom as a political, worldly system had been born. To be obedient to their understanding of the Lord's command to "take up one's cross," (Luke 9:23) they had withdrawn from the world and all its voices to seek solitude in the Egyptian desert. To them, solitude was not being alone, but being able to draw so close to God, that they would become unaware of all other people around them. They learned to be still, to develop an inner silence, to meditate upon Him and to hear His voice.

I'm sure we don't need to withdraw into a monastic lifestyle, but we do need to spend quality time if we would learn to recognise His voice. We do not need a great intellect that understands all theology, nor do we need a Bible College diploma or Seminary degree. He speaks, not to the intellect and mind, but to the spirit where His Spirit communicates to ours.

To Hear His Voice, We Need 1. A hunger - a passion - for His will.

2. A heart set on being obedient to whatever He wants.

3. Time spent in His Word.

4. A quiet place for meditation.

5. Inner silence and solitude.

"The Lord Told Me..." There is nothing so disconcerting to a pastor than to have someone come to you, supposedly for counsel, who begins the conversation by saying, "The Lord told me..." end of conversation!

I usually try to ask them how the Lord spoke to them, only to discover that, in my opinion, it was no more than a thought they had, possibly originating in the emotion of some meeting or in conversation with a friend, but seldom originating in the Lord. If only we would be quicker to ask

such a question whenever people say, “The Lord told me,” maybe we would stop people being so flippant in use of the expression.

For four years, my wife and I had the great privilege of working on a Mercy Ship traveling between Europe and West Africa. On board were doctors, surgeons, and nurses who volunteered their skills in performing life-changing operations for hundreds of unfortunate people who could not afford the high costs of surgery their maladies required. Though it was a very fulfilling time, there were many days of great stress and weariness, but to those in the developed nations who received the reports of the work being done by the medical staff and the rest of the ship’s crew, it must have seemed to be a very glamorous ministry.

I remember so many who came to work on the ship who said that they were there because the Lord had told them to come.

It always surprised me how many of them discovered, just a short time later, that it was not where they really wanted to be.

Obviously, the Lord had made some mistake, or they had mistaken his voice for another.

I have had others tell me that the Lord had told them to do something which was contrary to Scripture! I personally know two women who left their husbands because “the Lord told me to,” even though there was no evidence of unfaithfulness or mistreatment. One husband was a believer, but he had entered into a (perfectly legal) business arrangement with an unbeliever. The wife claimed that the Lord had told her to leave her husband because he was “unequally yoked” with an unbeliever! What a misuse of Scripture, and certainly not the Lord’s will for any marriage!

Many believers use this expression sincerely, believing they have been led by God. This may have been through a dream, the encouragement of a friend, circumstances, a verse of Scripture becoming prominent, ‘coincidences,’ or just a growing personal inner desire.

All of these are genuine ways, preferably collectively, that the Lord can lead us to walk in His will; however, it would be advisable to say “I believe the Lord would have me do this...” rather than the ‘spiritual’ expression, “The Lord told me...” which might do lots for the ego, but is often so damaging to Christian testimony.

That rare occasion is a personal testimony.

In my life, I have had a number of experiences where I knew His presence in a more-than-usual way. Let me emphasize that they are rare, not the norm. On two occasions I have heard Him speak to me in an audible voice. I do not try to explain these, and they certainly are not because I am more spiritual at those times than other times.

In fact, both times were when I was with a heavy heart. I will tell you about one of them.

It was 1983 and I had been pastor of the small Christian and Missionary Alliance church in Sidney on Vancouver Island, British Columbia, for less than one year. They were a warm, loving congregation and we had developed a deep attachment to many of them. However, prospects for the church to grow in numbers were not good, as there was a ‘freeze’ on local land development and suitable buildings were scarce.

In fact, we were meeting at the local headquarters of the Free Masons! I was not receiving a great salary, but it was evident that soon, the church’s limited expenses would exceed their even-more limited income. This small congregation were an off-shoot of the larger church in nearby Victoria, the capital city of the province, but there was now little relationship between the two, least of all any commitment by the mother church to underwrite the cost-overheads of the daughter.

It was a drizzling Sunday evening late in November. Anne had taken our three daughters to a meeting at the mother church while I decided to

walk and talk with the Lord concerning the growing heaviness upon my heart. Should I return to teaching?

Perhaps part time to augment my income so that it isn't as big of a burden on the church? Should I resign and seek another position, telling the church that they could not, at this time, afford a full-time minister? Should I put out a 'fleece' to try to find God's will? My mind was full of questions, but I was not receiving any answers!

My footsteps took me to the top of a local beauty spot from where one could look out over all the surrounding countryside.

Bear Hill had become a favorite retreat location for us, and it was at its summit that I rested. There, I found my 'burning bush.' I heard an audible voice!

Its words were clear and were repeated so that I could understand them clearly.

Though my spirit gave witness that this was a Divine moment, I looked around to see if there was anyone else on the hilltop with me. There was no one else present. The Lord was speaking, and His words were clear.

"You will pastor Victoria Alliance Church!"

There was no explanation how this would come about. At that time, Victoria Alliance Church had three pastors and the senior man had been there just about one year. He had his master's degree in theology while I had never been to seminary and had only recently been ordained. Maybe God wasn't speaking of the present time and His words had relevance only for the future? How would that answer my questions for the present?

Perhaps He meant that I was to approach the senior pastor and suggest that the mother church took over the daughter church again, and that I be taken on as their fourth pastor? Such were the thoughts racing through my mind as I returned home.

I told Anne of my experience and we decided to be silent about this, believing that if the Lord had truly spoken, He was perfectly able to bring about His purposes without our interference. Imagine our surprise just a couple of weeks later, to hear that the senior pastor had announced his resignation from the Victoria church!

We were tempted to telephone everyone at that church to tell them that we knew who was to be their next pastor, but we decided that discretion was a better choice and so remained silent. As an extra precaution, we stayed away from that church over the coming months, so we could not be tempted to manipulate their situation to bring about ‘God’s will’ for them.

It was several months later that the District Superintendent called to invite me to pastor the Victoria Alliance Church. I immediately responded in the affirmative, causing him to remark, “That was quick!”

“Brother,” I said, “I knew four months ago!”

During my seven years at the Victoria Alliance Church, there were many times that I was tempted to leave, but I stayed because I knew that the Lord had called me there and believed that He would call me out when it was time to go. We have no doubt that, when an invitation came in 1990 to serve on board the Mercy Ship, it was His time to move on.

Why did God speak in an audible voice? It certainly wasn’t because I was more spiritual than others nor because He had just woken up to my need! Maybe, just maybe, it was because my heaviness was so real that it had brought me to the place of solitude that I needed; the place of inner emptiness and silence where I could hear Him speak. Maybe, it was just His sovereign act of speaking into my pain out of His great love.

Relating this story reminds me of the words I once heard spoken by Floyd McClung, who was once a notable teacher with Youth With A Mission. He was speaking on the subject of prophecy, but his words could well apply to my circumstance in hearing the voice of God.

He said that whenever you receive a word of prophecy, put it in the bottom drawer and lock the drawer! It was not given to you for direction, it was given to you to build up your faith.

There will come a time when you will need to remember, possibly in a difficult situation, that God gave that word. You may then have confidence that He has brought you to this place, and most surely is able to bring you through.

I believe these to be very wise words, much needed in these days of multiple personal prophecies made from public pulpits. There are so many believers very confused by words of knowledge and prophecy that have been made over them, with little evidence of their fulfillment, and little accountability by their proponents. A charismatic gift really needed today is that of discernment.

My trust in the Lord is not built on these very rare experiences, instead, it is built upon the confidence that He is leading me every day as I hold on to his hand. I do not have to hear His voice audibly, but it is essential that my spirit is in tune with His so that He can lead me.

Corporate Prayer One of the greatest blessings I have received is in the area of corporate prayer. When I was a young believer, I found most prayer meetings rather boring as there were often repetitive prayers and little evidence of God answering. Things changed when the Lord began to do a wonderful work among the youth of our church. These young men and women began to pray for one another in a remarkable way. As it became evident, they were hearing the inner prompting of the Lord in the things they should pray for. I began to realize the power in corporate prayer when those praying are collectively hearing the Shepherd's voice.

I was leading a Missions Bridge School, in which our goal was to disciple eager believers and give them a mission's 'experience' in a developing, or third-world nation. One evening our topic was corporate prayer, so I

taught the twelve students a practice I had learned in my first church. We silenced our hearts in a quiet prayer and then I read a meditative psalm.

The students were then instructed to meditate in silence for the next fifteen minutes using the psalm as a basis for their meditation. On completion of the fifteen minutes - a very long time for most of us unaccustomed to such practice - I asked each person to tell us of their thoughts. They were to describe any pictures, relate any stories, or quote any Scriptures they had received, without trying to make any interpretation of their thoughts.

As each told of their thoughts, I began to look for a pattern.

My wife, Anne, was the last to speak. She is not given to charismatic experiences, but that evening she spoke of seeing a vision of a white ship sailing on black waters off the coast of Victoria, and I had seen a black cloud lifting over the city revealing a white ship on its waters!

I summed up their thoughts with words like this: "It seems that we have four themes running through our meditations. Several of you have spoken of our governments, both federal and provincial, our native peoples and this ship; I wonder how we are to pray."

That evening two dear friends had unexpectedly come to visit Anne and myself and were even now sitting at the side of the classroom. Robin and Anne Jones lived up-island, but were spending the evening in Victoria, taking in this Mission Bridge class, though not as students. Anne spoke up, "Gareth, please forgive me for interfering, but I think Robin has something very interesting to share."

I invited Robin to speak so he told us their reason for being in Victoria that evening. "At midnight, I shall be at Victoria airport with two local (provincial) politicians, greeting two federal politicians who are coming to discuss the purchase of a ship. This is to be used to develop a ministry to native peoples who are subject to the courts. Rather than committing first-time offenders to prison, we wish to begin a Christian ministry of taking

them to sea for a period of three weeks, training them in seamanship skills and teaching them Christian principles. This will be jointly funded by the provincial and federal governments.”

We had heard from God! He had revealed His heart to us, and we knew how to pray. That Mission Bridge class prayed that ministry into being, for He had given us faith appropriate to the need.

Hebrews 11

If Hebrews 11 isn't recorded for us as a list of the heroes of faith, what is its purpose? Why has the Holy Spirit, the author of all the Scripture, placed this chapter here?

As in all matters of Biblical interpretation, we need to consider the literary context. Up to Hebrews 10:18, the author has been writing about the practices and purposes of the Old Testament covenant, law, temple and sacrifices. These are contrasted with the better things found in Christ.

We have a better salvation (Hebrews 2), a better Law giver (Hebrews 3), a better rest (Hebrews 4), a better High Priest (Hebrews 5), a better covenant (Hebrews 8), a better promise (Hebrews 8), and a better sacrifice (Hebrews 9).

Beginning in Hebrews 10:19, the author introduces a new theme.

“Therefore, brothers, since we have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus... let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith... let us hold fast the confession of our hope without wavering... and let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works” (Hebrews 10:19, 22-24).

He is now writing to emphasize the lifestyle that should be characteristic of those who have experienced the ‘better things’ found in Christ.

“ But recall the former days when, after you were enlightened, you endured a hard struggle with sufferings... therefore do not throw away your

confidence, which has a great reward. For you have need of endurance, so that when you have done the will of God you may receive what is promised.

For, “Yet a little while, and the coming one will come and will not delay; but my righteous one shall live by faith, and if he shrinks back, my soul has no pleasure in him.” But we are not of those who shrink back and are destroyed, but of those who have faith and preserve their souls” (Hebrews 10:32, 35-39).

The next chapter is written to give us examples of ‘living by faith.’ It is striking that Caleb, Elisha and Daniel are missing while Moses (a murderer), Sarah (who laughed at God’s promise), and Rahab (a liar) are present. It does not take a spiritual giant to walk the walk of faith. Anyone, whatever their spiritual maturity, can begin this exciting journey of walking in faith today, without which it is impossible to please God. Another example of God’s amazing grace!

“Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen” (Hebrews 11:1). We have already considered verse one as a definition of faith, a gift and a fruit.

“For by it the people of old received their commendation” (Hebrews 11:2). Men and women of old, who walked in faith, had a good testimony, a good report. Others looked at them and knew that such people walked with God. There were lessons to be learned by watching how God worked in their lives. Similarly, our lives should also be a testimony of faith - revealing God’s leading and our obedience to that leading. The world does not want to hear our words of believing because to them it is irrational. They want to see the witness of our lives.

We are not called to stand in the world giving testimony to Christ; we are called to stand in Christ giving testimony to the world.

“By faith we understand that the universe was created by the word of God, so that what is seen was not made out of things that are visible.” (He-

brews 11:3). All religions have their stories about creation.

The foundation of our faith is found in an uncreated God Who called all creation into being by His Word. This is beyond human comprehension and scientific explanation. All science can do is investigate what is already in existence and stand back in awe as it proves the reality of what is written! It is only possible to comprehend when God has granted an inner revelation, the faith to enable us to believe. This is not replacing reason, it is above all reason, “for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him” (Hebrews 11:6).

We shall now begin to consider each of the characters named in Hebrews 11 to see how the Lord led them in the walk of faith. Coming from the standpoint that the Holy Spirit deliberately led His human author in the choice of people named, I ask myself to read beyond the words to see what principles of the walk with God He has made evident in these examples. I am thrilled as I see the great truths of The Faith being revealed.

I pray that the following chapters will excite you as we consider them together. May the Holy Author speak to your soul concerning what He has written here.

Cain and Abel

“By faith Abel offered to God a more acceptable sacrifice than Cain, through which he was commended as righteous, God commending him by accepting his gifts. And through his faith, though he died, he still speaks” (Hebrews 11:4).

The original story of Cain and Abel can be found in Genesis 4:1-8.

A question often asked in Sunday School quizzes is, “Who was the first man to shed blood?” There is no convincing reason to believe that Adam had not slain an animal for food, but the first recorded shedding of blood is that of Abel shedding the blood of a lamb. Students, in their eagerness to answer, often say that the first was Cain who shed the blood of his brother in an act of murder.

Cain was the first-born son to Adam and Eve. His mother was so excited. Surely he was the ‘seed’ promised by God in His declaration of war against the serpent who had deceived her (Genesis 3:15). She named him Cain - which means “spear” - saying “I have a man from the Lord.” She soon realizes her mistake once he grew up with all the characteristics of any other baby to be born; he was probably just as naughty!

Another son is born whom she names Abel - which means “vanity” - realizing that the battle is not to be over as soon as she had thought. Such hoping had been in vain. Evidently, there were to be other ‘seeds,’ so which of them would be the one to wound the serpent’s head?

Years pass during which time there is no communion with God, no worship, only a deep sense of guilt in the parents and a growing questioning and desire in the two sons. I can imagine their lives in those early days, just outside the walls, and see them asking their parents about the garden and the cherubim who stood guard over its gate. I wonder if Adam or Eve were ever able to tell their sons of what had happened within those walls - it would have hardly been a story that they would want to remember! However, there has always been in man a desire to worship, whether it is the Living God or any of the multitude of gods represented in the variety of religions of the world. Cain and Abel would have been no different.

As the boys grew up, they developed different interests. Cain worked the land and became a tiller of the ground, producing beautiful flowers, vegetables, fruit, and herbs. He followed his father who toiled in the fields all the days of his life. The younger son, Abel, became a shepherd, wandering with the animals as they sought good pasture.

It was Cain who first thought of bringing a gift to God. We do not know his purpose, but there is no reason to believe this to be anything less than a genuine, thankful offering, (the Hebrew language would certainly imply that). Maybe there was hope that God might show him favor and allow him back inside the garden. Where should he take the basket of produce he had washed, polished, and put together so carefully? Possibly to the gate guarded by the cherubim. The basket looked so beautiful with all its varied colors and aromas. He placed the basket before the angel as his brother watched.

Brother Abel wonders what he can bring as an offering to God.

He doesn't want to be left out if there is any chance to appease God, but he has no beautiful produce to bring. Indeed, he has nothing he has obtained by the sweat of his brow. All he has is some cattle, goats and sheep.

By faith he offered a better sacrifice. What does that mean?

We read that “Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the word of God” (Romans 10:17). Evidently, God spoke to Abel. I am reminded of Jesus’ words to Peter on Mount Hermon, recorded for us in Matthew 16:17 which reads, “Blessed are you... for flesh and blood have not revealed this to you, but My Father who is in heaven.”

God’s voice was not the voice of thunder, nor the voice recognized by the senses, but only by the inner voice heard by the soul and often gone unrecognized as being His.

Abel, in response to the inner voice, decided, “I will bring a lamb. A young lamb, a firstling. I will kill it, dress it, and bring it with its fat.” So, he presents his offering before the angel at the gate. His faith was evidenced in obedience to the inner voice.

The next action belongs to God. It is He who has led both men here as He wants to teach them - and us - some vital principles of the righteous life. “He had regard for Abel and his offering, but for Cain and his offering He had no regard” (Genesis 4:4).

The Destructive Power of Offense The men are important as well as their offerings. God knows the heart of man and knows the man to whom He can trust His revelation and prompting.

He said to Moses that He knew his name (character) and would therefore reveal His name (character), and glory to Moses (Exodus 33:12-34:8). When Simon declared that Jesus was the Messiah, his master realized that such knowledge had come by revelation from God. Though he often spoke out of turn and he had minimal education, his heart was right, so God gave revelation.

Knowing that this was a testimony to his character, Jesus renamed him Peter - which means, “a rock.” How does God see our hearts? Does He see a character that will please Him?

What name would He give you? Does He see one to whom He can reveal His glory, knowing that you will not usurp some of that glory for yourself? Does he see one whose heart is pure, one to whom He can reveal Himself (Matthew 5:8)? A pure heart is single-focused, unalloyed by love for things of the world.

Cain did no wrong in bringing his offering to God. In fact he should be commended for his actions; however, God knew that there was potential in Cain for offense that leads to sin.

Offense in itself is not sin. Jesus caused offense to the Pharisees, the scribes, and even some of His friends, yet without sin. However, it is a weapon greatly used by Satan to rob believers of their victory, and has become a source of more church splits than anything else in his arsenal. Sadly, more and more people are leaving the spiritual battlefield because they get offended. The number one reason that missionaries leave the field and pastors leave their pulpits is not finances, ill health, visa or language difficulties, but because they, or someone they work with, have been offended.

Here is a brief outline of five Scriptural examples of people being offended and what it cost them.

1. In Matthew 13:20-21 one is offended by the Word. For example, they don't like its call to commitment, and as a result, there was no spiritual fruit (Galatians 5:22-23).

2. In Matthew 13:53-58 familiarity breeds contempt: they got offended (Matthew 13:57)! As a result, there was no supernatural ministry. No answers to prayer, and no revelation.

3. In Matthew 26:6-10 the disciples (especially Judas) are offended (John 12:4 and Matthew 26:8). As a result, there was no confidence, and Judas goes out to betray his Lord (Matthew 26:14).

4. In Matthew 26:31-35 the disciples are offended because they do not understand. As a result, there was no testimony.

Peter, “the rock,” crumbles before a little girl.

5. In John 6:51-61 the disciples are offended at Jesus’ call to commitment. As a result there was no communion or fellowship. “From that time, many of His disciples went back, and walked with Him no more” (John 6:66).

God would challenge Cain just as Jesus challenged those He loved. John the Baptist was offended by Jesus when He did not visit him in prison, and Mary was offended by Him because He did not rush to prevent the death of Lazarus (Matthew 11:2-6 and John 11:1-35). Indeed, I would suggest that the reason Jesus wept was because of the way she spoke to Him when finally, she came to see Him outside Bethany. She used the same words as her sister Martha, “Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died” (John 11:32), but the response of Jesus was very different. Surely, He did not weep for Lazarus, nor the professional mourners, for He had known of their situation since He had decided not to come at their first call. He also knew that in a few minutes they would all be rejoicing at the Resurrection.

The Lord allows offenses to come into our lives to teach us something about ourselves, about the condition of our hearts.

When we allow offense to become sin we reveal a character to whom God will not give revelation, nor the prompting of faith.

The Atoning Power of the Blood Secondly, God had regard for the offering of Abel, but not that of Cain. Some have said that this is because Cain should have known that to approach God, he ought to have shed a lamb’s blood, but how would he have known that? Further, he had no sheep - they belonged to Abel. I believe that kind of reasoning is putting the cart before the horse. God chose the offering of Abel in order to teach them, and us, what was previously unknown . The only way man can approach God is through the shed blood of a lamb. There was nothing wrong with Cain’s offering, but God chose Abel’s. Indeed, later, when God would

institute various kinds of offering for the feast days of His people, the produce of the field was a very acceptable offering (Leviticus 6:14-23).

Throughout the Old Testament, we read of God reaching out to His creation seeking to win them back into fellowship with Himself. He finds few whose hearts are pure before Him until, at the flood, He wipes all but one family of eight people off the face of the earth. Later He calls out a special people for Himself and reveals to them His will in the Ten Commandments. They prove themselves incapable of the righteousness demanded by that Law, so He reveals how He will deal with their sinfulness.

For all forms of uncleanness, blood had to be shed. This was especially true of that annual great Day of Atonement when the sins of the people and the nation were to be covered over for another year. Amidst great ceremony and ritual, a lamb was taken. It was to be 'spotless,' a one-year-old male. Its blood was poured into a basin and taken by the High Priest into the most holy place in the tabernacle or temple, where it would be offered before God. All the nation would wait with bated breath hoping that God would accept this sacrifice for another year. The rejoicing would have been great when the High Priest returned to them unharmed. God had been pleased again to accept them as His people!

These Old Testament rituals were but a shadow of that which was fulfilled in the death of Jesus, the Lamb of God, at the cross of Calvary; however, He did not shed His blood that our sins might be covered for another year. The death of the perfect lamb was to remove our sins completely, as far as the east is from the west, into the depths of the sea (Psalms 103:12). To those who have placed their trust in the finished work of Calvary, there is no more condemnation but an access into the presence and fellowship of God. Paradise has been regained!

Cain's Response Cain's heart was revealed. He was very angry, and his countenance fell. The Lord asked him why he was angry and asked him an

interesting question. “If you do well, will you not be accepted? And if you do not do well, sin is crouching at the door; its desire is contrary to you, but you must rule over it” (Genesis 4:7).

Evidently, Cain had not yet sinned! There was no sin in his approach to God nor in his offering. Cain’s attitude was wrong, his taking offense was wrong, but the fruit of sin had not yet come.

He must master sin’s temptation and do well; however, he fails. Abel is slain and Cain is cast out, nevertheless with God’s mark of protection upon him.

In considering this story, Jewish commentators have an interesting understanding of the question posed by God. They see it as an early reference to tithing! Cain’s offering was not acceptable because he had not ‘rightly divided’ his produce.

They interpret Genesis 4:7 as, “If you had rightly divided, would not your offering have been accepted?”

Summary As I read the story of Cain and Abel in the context of faith, I see the Lord teaching us the following principles: 1. Approach to a Holy God is only through the shed blood of a lamb, the perfect type of the coming Lamb of God, Jesus.

2. God knows the heart of man and will only reveal Himself to those who are pure in heart.

3. God permits offenses to come to teach us about our heart’s potential to sin.

Enoch

“By faith Enoch was taken up so that he should not see death, and he was not found, because God had taken him. Now before he was taken he was commended as having pleased God.”

(Hebrews 11:5).

The story of Enoch is very briefly recorded in Genesis 5:18-24.

Another children's Bible quiz question asks, “Who was the oldest man who ever lived?” Methuselah, the son of Enoch!

Enoch lived on Earth for 365 years, walking with God before ‘God took him.’ This walking with God was a walk of faith, without which it is impossible to please God (Hebrews 11:6).

He knew what it was to fellowship closely with his creator, to hear His voice and to know His guidance.

How sweet that fellowship must have been! Although Enoch showed evidence of the fall of Adam and Eve, he still enjoyed the presence of God. Today also, when all around us might seem corrupt, and evil appears to prevail, the child of God who walks by faith can still have sweet fellowship with his Lord.

History is replete with stories of believers whose circumstances were most difficult, but whose testimony was radiant because they knew the Divine presence.

“By faith Enoch was taken up” (Hebrews 11:5).

What does this mean? Surely it is not that Enoch believed so much that he would be taken up, that God did it for him!

Instead, it was God's sovereign act that took him up, in order to teach us a great truth!

The Hope of Resurrection What Biblical principle can we learn from this short account that has meaning for us today?

Clearly, there is the principle of eternal life .

For those who walk with God in faith, there is the promise of Resurrection, or rapture at His second coming, unto eternal life. Both Paul and Peter, when standing before the people, declared that this is the hope of all believers. Indeed, Paul knew this was the main cause of his persecution. "I am on trial for the hope and Resurrection of the dead" (Acts 23:6). Other religions might teach reincarnation, or a salvation based upon works of righteousness; however, our message is unwavering in its declaration of a Resurrection unto eternal life for all who walk by faith with God.

This hope for which Paul and Peter, and all the apostles, were willing to die, is based on a fact - as is all Christian hope, unlike the hopes of the world. May I remind you that Christian hope is best defined as "an eager expectation for that which is certain." Our hope of Resurrection is founded in the most glorious event of all history; the Resurrection of Jesus from the dead.

When one looks objectively at all the stories, theories, and opinions about that first Easter Sunday, he must come to the conclusion that the most attested fact of all history is that Jesus of Nazareth, having been crucified on a Roman cross, and buried in a borrowed tomb, rose from the dead, and resurrected into new life.

He appeared to the disciples and many others. The apostle Paul records that more than 500 brethren were eyewitnesses of His new life, almost all of whom were still alive to testify to that fact at the time of the apostle's writ-

ing many years later. These men had nothing to gain by perpetrating a lie and everything to lose by insisting on the truth. There was great persecution towards the believers, many of whom lost their lives because they would not deny what to them was fact.

Tradition tells us that each of the apostles, except John, were martyred for what they knew-that Jesus rose from the dead!

Now they understood what He had meant when He taught them, "Yet a little while and the world will see me no more, but you will see me. Because I live, you also will live" (John 14:19). This was to be their hope - an eager expectation for that which is sure - and the promise exemplified in the testimony of Enoch.

The Resurrection of Jesus is the fundamental argument of our Christian belief. Without it, there is no Christianity. Such a religion would be no different than all others since it cannot offer hope. It is also important for the following reasons: 1. It shows the justice of God who exalted Christ to a life of glory, as Christ had humbled Himself unto death (Philippians 2:8-9).

2. The Resurrection completed the mystery of our salvation and redemption. By His death, Christ freed us from the penalty of sin (Romans 5:8), by His suffering He freed us from the curse of the Law (Galatians 3:13), and by His Resurrection He restored to us the most important privileges lost by sin (Romans 4:25).

3. By His Resurrection we acknowledge Christ as the immortal God, the efficient and exemplary cause of our own Resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:21 and Philippians 3:20-21) and as the model and source of our new life of grace (Romans 6:4-6 and Romans 6:9-11).

Paul's Testimony It was because of their hope of Resurrection to eternal life that the early believers were persecuted. The Scripture records for us the testimony of the apostle Paul standing before the chief priests and the

Council on trial. “It is with respect to the hope and the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial” (Acts 23:6).

The Council was made up of two main parties: the religious Pharisees, believers in a Resurrection of the law-keepers, and the political Sadducees, non-believers. Naturally, there was dissension at Paul’s words, so the troops were ordered to take Paul back to his cell.

Now a political conspiracy arose with the purpose of assassinating the apostle, but the Roman military commander was made aware of the plot, so he ordered that Paul be taken to Antipatris where Felix, the Roman governor, had his palace.

Before the governor, Paul repeats his hope in the Resurrection, both of the righteous to life, and the wicked to judgment (Acts 24:15,21).

Not knowing what to do with Paul or how to appease his accusers, Felix kept him in prison until, two years later he was succeeded by a new governor, Festus. The apostle was made a spectacle, being called to speak of his ‘foolish’ belief before Festus and his guests, King Agrippa and his wife Bernice. Paul does not stand down before this audience. Again he asserts, “I am standing trial for this great hope, O King. Why should it seem unbelievable to you people, that God should raise the dead?” (Acts 26:7-8). Later he would appear before Caesar where we can be sure, he did not hesitate to give the same testimony, even though it resulted in his death. But why should he fear death? He had already written: “Behold! I tell you a mystery . We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. For this perishable body must put on the imperishable, and this mortal body must put on immortality. When the perishable puts on the imperishable, and the mortal puts on immortality, then shall come to pass the saying that is written: ‘Death is swallowed up in victory.’ ‘Oh death, where is your victory? O

death, where is your sting?’ The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law. But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ” (1 Corinthians 15:51-57).

This is not a new truth, but a mystery . Whenever Paul writes about a mystery, he is referring to a truth that has always been, but which is only now being revealed (Romans 16:25-26).

It was Jesus who first spoke about the mystery of the kingdom (Mark 4:11), but Paul also used this expression many times.

A good theme for personal Bible Study would be to examine the following references: the mystery of the Gentiles ‘grafting in’ (Romans 11:25), the mystery of His will (Ephesians 1:9), the mystery of Gentiles (Ephesians 3:3), the mystery of marriage (Ephesians 5:32), the mystery of the Gospel (Ephesians 6:19), the mystery of Christ in you (Colossians 1:26-27), the mystery of Christ Himself (Colossians 2:2), the mystery of iniquity (2 Thessalonians 2:7), the mystery of the faith (1 Timothy 3:9), and the mystery of godliness (1 Timothy 3:16).

This mystery, this truth, this glorious hope of resurrection to eternal life, was first revealed to us in the testimony of Enoch.

Summary “By faith, Enoch was translated” (Hebrews 11:5), so that we might know we have a glorious hope; that of eternal life.

This is not a New Testament doctrine, but has always been part of God’s purposes for His people.

Noah

“By faith Noah, being warned by God concerning events as yet unseen, in reverent fear constructed an ark for the saving of his household. By this he condemned the world and became an heir of the righteousness that comes by faith” (Hebrews 11:7).

The story of Noah and the ark can be found in Genesis 6:5-7:24 Here we have an example of a man who found grace in the eyes of the Lord. He was a righteous man, blameless among his generation, who walked with God (Genesis 6:9).

In Genesis 6:13, God spoke to Noah. It isn't hard to know what the Lord wants from you when He speaks to you.

It was not hard to believe God, but Noah did more than just believe; he obeyed, doing all that God commanded him. This is faith! Belief demonstrated in obedient action.

The instructions given to Noah were very strange, but he still obeyed them all. He had never seen a flood nor a boat, but at God's command, he started work and did not rest until the work was complete. We do not read of anyone, including his sons who helped Noah in this gigantic project, but they and their wives were to benefit from Noah's obedience. In all, eight people would owe their lives to God's grace and Noah's obedience.

What Biblical Principle can we learn from this example of faith?

One clear answer is given by Jesus Himself in Matthew 24:37-39 where He teaches the Jews concerning His return to set up His Messianic

kingdom.

As it was in the days of Noah so it shall be at the coming of the Son of Man. In those days before the flood, they were eating, drinking, and marrying until the day when Noah entered the ark. They did not know why until the flood came and swept them all away; so it will be with the coming of the Son of Man.

People will be mindless of the things of God, therefore great judgment shall come upon them. Only a few - a remnant - being saved.

There is the principle of the certainty of a coming judgment upon this world; however, another truth would be seen in the provision God has made for us through His Son, Jesus. He has prepared the means whereby we might be saved from the judgment coming on all who refuse to walk with Him.

An ark has been prepared in Jesus and the invitation is given to whoever will enter! We thank the Lord that He was obedient to the Father's will, even though it meant the agony of Gethsemane and a cross on Golgotha's hill. Because of the Father's grace and the Son's obedience, all who enter find salvation.

As God closed the door of Noah's ark when all eight were inside (Genesis 7:16), so He has 'sealed us' in His Son by the Holy Spirit (Ephesians 1:13). Not only is there security in our ark Jesus, but there we are blessed with every spiritual blessing (Ephesians 1:3). Indeed, all of Ephesians 1 speaks of such blessings.

In Him: ● We are made holy and blameless (v.4).

- We are made God's children (v.5).
- We receive God's abundant grace. (v.6).
- We have redemption (bought back from bondage) and we have forgiveness of our sins (v.7).
- God shows us the mystery of His will (v.9).

- God will unite all creation (v.10).
- We are appointed to live for the praise of His glory (v.11).
- We are sealed with His Holy Spirit (v.13).

Then in Ephesians 2:6, Paul writes that we have been raised up to be seated in heavenly places in Him, so that God might show the immeasurable riches of His grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus.

Our security is not in our ability to build our own ark, nor in our good works. Our own righteousness will not avail. We cannot escape by our own inventions or schemings; rather, it is all by grace, through faith. God has planned and prepared a way of salvation. He invites us to enter in. We may believe, but if we are not obedient to His invitation, we shall not be saved. Saving faith requires an obedient response.

Further, everyone who lived near to Noah would be aware of this amazing vessel he was building. All would know what he preached, but none were willing to respond to his invitation.

The people were condemned by their refusal to accept what was evident before their eyes. Similarly, the good news of salvation in Jesus is not hidden from the world today, but men choose not to respond to the invitation; hence the presence of the church is still a condemnation of the world.

Summary The story of Noah as an example of faith teaches us the following principles: 1. There is a judgment coming upon the world.

2. God, in grace, has made a way of escape in His Son, Jesus, and salvation is found in none other.

3. Grace is a fundamental attribute of God.

4. Salvation demands obedient response to God's invitation.

That, is saving faith .

Abraham

“By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to a place that he was to receive as an inheritance. And he went out, not knowing where he was going. By faith he went to live in the land of promise, as in a foreign land, living in tents with Isaac and Jacob, heirs with him of the same promise. For he was looking forward to the city that has foundations, whose designer and builder is God” (Hebrews 11:8-10).

The classic example of the life of faith, used by Paul, James, and the author of the book to the Hebrews, was the wanderer Abraham, and his story is recorded in Genesis 11-25. The writer of Hebrews emphasizes here the faith displayed by Abraham as a sojourner, one without any ties to his own possessions.

As we compare the verses of Hebrews above with the historic account found in Genesis 11:31 we see that, though God was calling Abram (later Abraham) to the promised land of Canaan, it was through his father Terah that he left Ur of the Chaldees. God often leads his children through the decisions of others. It was not until he had left Haran that God spoke directly to Abram. He was the chosen vessel through whom God would establish His people and their land.

Unlike Noah, Abram was not chosen because he was righteous, indeed he lived in an idolatrous country with little knowledge of God. Among the men who came before him there were many who worshiped God, but none of these was chosen to be the Father of the great nation of God’s people.

Abel was good, he offered sacrifices according to God's will, but he offered for himself alone. He was not specially chosen.

Enoch and Noah were also individuals in their walk with God.

All three worshiped the true God, but none of them was specially chosen to start the recovery of what was lost by Adam.

It was Abram whom God chose, and he was an idolator (Joshua 24:2)! God called Abram because He had a special reason - Abram was to be the starting point of divine recovery from the fall. When we turn to the New Testament, the first words we read are, "The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham" (Matthew 1:1). God starts His good news (the Gospel) with Abraham!

When God spoke, Abram obeyed. He did not understand, nor did he stop to discuss plans with God. He just obeyed and 'went out.' He could have complained that he was already 75 years old and too old to start wandering, but he didn't. He went out not knowing where he was going. He had heard of a land, a kingdom that was to be his inheritance. He had heard the promise that his name would be great and that he would be a blessing to all the peoples of the earth.

Though he had not known God before this time, there was a confidence planted in him to believe that the promises of God were sure. So, he went out... God is looking for men and women today whose eyes are fixed on His kingdom and not the vanity fairs of this world. The hymnist of the 695 th Trinity Hymnal declares, "I am a stranger here within a foreign land, My home is far away upon a golden strand.

Ambassador am I of things beyond the sky, I'm here on business for my King."

A.P Carter, has expressed it this way in his hymn, "This World is Not My Home:" "This world is not my home, I'm just a'passing through.

My treasures are laid up somewhere beyond the blue.

The angels beckon me from Heaven's open door, and I can't feel at home in this world any more!"

The apostle John exhorts us not to love the world, nor the things of the world (1 John 2:15). Of course, we are to love the people of this world and its beauties which cause us to worship God, but John is referring to the systems of men's makings: its politics and guile, its secular humanism and compromise, and its vanity and materialism. Abraham had no interest in such things for he was a sojourner, one passing through, and his was a walk with God, a walk of faith.

I am reminded of the prodigal son in the parable told by Jesus in Luke 15. He went out and wasted his portion of the inheritance on the pleasures of the world. Coming to his senses, he returned home in penitence saying, "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son. Treat me as one of your hired servants" (Luke 15:18-19) However, the father receives him warmly, clothing him with the best robes, putting shoes on his feet, and arranging a party for him much to the chagrin of the older brother. Though I recognize myself in the prodigal, knowing my guilt and acknowledging the love of the Father who still accepts me as His son, I see little in him to commend him, until I compare him with the elder son!

The older son complains to the father about the treatment given to the prodigal. "He has brought shame to us, he has wasted his inheritance lusting after this world, while I have remained faithful at home. Why have you killed the fatted calf for him? You have never treated me that way!" (Luke 15:28-30). What smug hypocrisy! The father replies, "My son, all the fatted calves belong to you! Everything that is left is your inheritance!" (Luke 15:31). The prodigal had lusted after the pleasures of this world, but he had now come to his senses in penitent remorse.

The elder son also lusted after things of this world - not wine, women, and song - but his possessions. He owned the farm and didn't want anything to rob him of his inheritance. In truth, the farm owned him !

It is not wrong to have possessions in this world, but the walk of faith demands that, like Abraham, they do not own us! Hold on to them lightly so that, when the Lord calls you to go, nothing will be holding you back. This is certainly the reason why believers should never be in debt. When we owe someone some money and are unable to meet that obligation at a moment's call, we are in bondage to that person and not free to answer when the Lord calls us 'to go out.' In truth we are serving Mammon, and not God at that moment. I would suggest that this is such a serious matter to the Lord that we should not even bring our tithes and offerings to His altar if another has something against us. i.e., we are in debt to him.

We should get out of debt even before giving our tithes to God (Matthew 5:23-26).

Maybe this is what the Lord meant when He said, "let the greatest among you become as the youngest, and the leader as one who serves" (Luke 22:26). The difference between the brothers was their attitudes to the things of the world. The older brother was concerned lest his inheritance be wasted on a party for the prodigal returnee. He wanted no one to rock his boat, he was content with the status quo. Similarly, Esau would sell his birthright for a present, temporary satisfaction, while his younger brother Jacob, though a deceiver, was a wanderer who walked - and wrestled - with God.

Like the prodigal, Jacob was brought to repentance, but not Esau. One had his inheritance in God; the other in a 'mess of pottage.' It is striking that God would declare, "I have loved Jacob but I have hated Esau" (Malachi 1:3). It is further worthy of note that the promises given to the idolator Abram were repeated to the deceiver Jacob, and he also, was to be-

come one of the three great patriarchs of the Jewish people, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

God is looking for men and women like Abraham. People willing to be led by the Lord exactly when and where He wants to lead them. To us He still says, “Seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness” (Matthew 6:33).

We shall consider Abraham again in a later chapter where we see more evidence of his faith walk with God, evidence also called up by James and Paul the apostles, in their writings.

Summary Abraham is presented to us in Hebrews 11 to teach us these principles: 1. God does not choose a man because of anything he might claim to be. Instead He chooses weak and foolish things, low and despised things, so that no man may boast (1 Corinthians 1:27-29).

2. People of faith are those whose eyes and heart are fixed on a heavenly kingdom; whose attitude is that of the ‘younger,’ having loose attachments to this world.

3. God started the work of redemption in a man who would become the prime example of the walk of faith, demonstrated in obedient trust.

Sarah

“By faith Sarah herself received power to conceive, even when she was past the age, since she considered him faithful who had promised. Therefore from one man, and him as good as dead, were born descendants as many as the stars of heaven and as many as the innumerable grains of sand by the seashore” (Hebrews 11:11-12).

The account of Sarah can be found in Genesis 18:9-15, and Genesis 21:1-7.

As we read the Genesis account, we are struck by the apparent lack of belief that Sarah shows, and would certainly not regard her as a candidate for a great heroine of faith if such is to be equated with belief. Indeed, Sarah continually reveals her human nature as she plans and schemes with her husband.

God had told Abraham that he would have an heir and would be the father of a great nation, but Sarah is barren, and reason would declare that the promise of God is vain. She, however, will have a child, even if it means giving her maid, Hagar, to be a sex partner for Abraham. The child is to belong to Sarah, but, when she sees Hagar with the boy, human jealousy rises in her breast and Hagar is driven from the home.

From this son, Ishmael, the great Arab nations are to come, and the world continues to reap their whirlwind. Note that it is God Himself who has raised up these nations, but His covenant remains with the children of the promise (Genesis 18:19). Do not be surprised at the ongoing enmity be-

tween the Arab nations and the children of Israel; there will always be antagonism between the fruit of carnal humanity and the fruit of God's promise. For example, Jesus told His disciples to tarry in Jerusalem for (another) promise of His Father, - the baptism with the Holy Spirit (Acts 1:4,5).

Isn't it amazing that the carnal outworking of this promise is so often discord and antagonism among God's people rather than the great power it should be to enable us to be the witnesses Christ has called us to be!? Ishmael was birthed out of human plans and schemes whereas Isaac was birthed 'by faith.' All the worlds' religions are founded upon the teachings and principles of carnal ingenuity, but the church of Jesus Christ is comprised of a people justified by faith.

We then see Sarah and Abraham scheming to deceive Abimelech, king of Gerar, by pretending that they were siblings. Abraham was afraid that the Gerites might kill him as Sarah's husband, so that Abimelech might take her as his wife. If the king thought they were siblings, he might still take Sarah but, at least, the life of Abraham would be spared! Does this read to you as people having great faith in God?

That is, if it is to be equated with trust. How striking that the heathen king, Abimelech, had more integrity of heart and fear of God than the man of faith! He restored Sarah to her husband, having not abused the sanctity of their marriage and giving them many gifts as vindication before all the people.

God honored Abimelech and his household, but His hand was still on Abraham and Sarah to lead them in the deeds of faith.

By faith (the action or gift of God), Sarah was able to conceive.

Though over 90 years of age, the child of promise, Isaac, was born. The couple came together in intercourse and God quickened both the sperm and ova so that conception took place. When Sarah accepted that the morn-

ing sickness was evidence of God's faithfulness, that was the evidence of her faith. She did not struggle against what was happening within her despite it being contrary to everything she, or anyone she knew, had experienced at that age. Her body would not reject, nor would she abort what God was birthing within her.

We often reject the workings of the Holy Spirit in our lives because we do not understand! How often do we abort that gift or ministry God would birth within us because we are afraid to pay the price!? Not for Sarah.

Lessons To Learn from Sarah's Faith Firstly, God is faithful to His promises even when it seems to be impossible. Indeed, with Him, nothing is impossible!

Secondly, God is looking for a people of faith that can be led by Him rather than politics or schemes. The church today is so full of man's plans and organization that there is no place for the Holy Spirit to move.

Sarah produced one son by scheming. The result has been great sorrow for the people of God throughout the centuries since. Her other son was 'by faith,' the son of promise. From him God has established His covenant people, through whom all nations of the earth will be blessed. They are to be the nation who brought us the Bible and the Messiah, our Saviour, Jesus.

God's Work in God's Way I am reminded of the time that King David would bring the ark of the covenant back to Jerusalem. The story is told for us in 1 Chronicles 13 and 15. To the Hebrews, the ark represented the presence of God among His people, but it had been out of the land for 20 years after being taken in battle by the Philistines during the carnal priesthood of Eli. For seven months the Philistines had suffered greatly while the ark was in their land, so they had set it on a new cart drawn by milch cows which had never previously been yoked together.

God allowed them to bring the ark safely back across the borders of Israel without sickness or injury; however, when David tried to use the same method to bring ‘God’s presence’ back to Jerusalem, his trained oxen slipped, and death resulted.

David was very angry with God, but soon had to repent when he read God’s method for carrying the ark, recorded in Numbers 4. God had brought judgment upon His people “because they did not seek him according to the rule” (1 Chronicles 15:13).

It is my opinion that the anointing of God’s presence and power is sadly missing from so much of what we call church.

Could this be because we are trying to build His church our way and not the way He has ordained? Indeed, could it be that we are not building His church at all, but our church? He has never promised to put His anointing on anything that is done in man’s strength or wisdom, but He has said, “I will build My church and the gates of Hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18). Further, He will build His church on the rock, as exemplified in Peter! Which characteristic of Peter is the Master referring to? Surely not his impetuous, carnal behavior! I suggest that the rock is faith such as the apostle demonstrated by his confession of Jesus as the Christ. “You are blessed, Peter. My Father has revealed this to you” said Jesus (Matthew 16:17). Faith here is seen in revelation followed by confession; God’s initiative followed by man’s response.

Isn’t it about time we returned to doing God’s work in God’s way?

It is time we got back to being people of the book, basing our work and walk on its principles and precepts. I am convinced that when we do God’s work in God’s way, we shall receive the anointing of His quickening upon our efforts. For example, we have many plans and schemes to evangelize to the people around us. We use ‘Four Spiritual Laws’ or ‘The Roman Road.’ We learn A-B-C tactics like salesmen and plan ‘seeker-sensitive services.’ We

write many tracts and put on evangelistic programs. All of these are good, but are they God's way?

I challenge you to pull one single sheet out of your Bible that you give away as a gospel tract. Can you find one scheme that the early church developed which we could emulate today?

Surely the Holy Spirit could have moved another of the disciples, say Andrew or Philip, who could have produced a book made up of "Tracts Sure to Succeed," or "Fifty Ways to Win Your Friends to Jesus" if that were the Spirit's plan of Salvation! We could have printed it as the last book in the Bible with 'pull-out' sheets for convenience.

I am convinced that the Bible does contain God's plan for salvation; however, though we cannot pull out one page to give away as a gospel tract, we can pull out entire books which emphasize His method . It is the unity of His people !

"Father I pray that they may be one, so that the world may believe that you have sent me; so that the world may know that you have loved them even as you love me" (John 17).

All our plans and schemes will produce some fruit, for He is a God of grace, but a full harvest will never come until we do it God's way. He wants to build His church, and give us the nations, but He will only do it His way.

His way is the way of faith and, one way this is demonstrated is by our unity in the Spirit.

Summary The example of Sarah, the schemer who laughed at God, is given to us to teach us the following principles: 1. With God all things are possible.

2. Human reasoning and faith are contradictory.
3. God's destiny for us will only be achieved by faith.
4. We must do God's work in God's way!

The Confession of Faith

“These all died in faith , not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth. For people who speak thus make it clear that they are seeking a homeland. If they had been thinking of that land from which they had gone out, they would have had the opportunity to return. But as it is, they desire a better country, that is, a heavenly one. Therefore God is not ashamed to be called their God, for he has prepared for them a city” (Hebrews 11:13-16).

It would appear that the writer of this book is referring to the ‘many’ of verse 12, the descendants of Abraham and Sarah who died before the coming of Jesus, their Messiah. In their times of faith and trust in Yahweh, they acknowledged their need for Him, “confessing that they were strangers and exiles on the earth” (Hebrews 11:13). Whether in Egypt, the wilderness, or Babylon, the children of Israel would know a deep longing in their hearts for home, that place promised to them in God’s words to Abraham, but only a few of them could ever put down roots anywhere other than in Canaan or Palestine.

“By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion. On the willows there we hung up our harps, for there our captors required of us songs and our tormentors, mirth, saying ‘Sing us one of the songs of Zion.’

How shall we sing the Lord’s song in a foreign land?” (Psalm 137:1-4).

They could have stayed in the country of their birth, but the heart of a sojourner was in them. This is characteristic of all true descendants of Abraham: that they do not feel at home in this world. There has been born within them a hunger for higher things, a heavenly city whose builder and maker is God.

It is God who has placed this longing in them by His initiating act of faith. People of faith will always respond to that yearning.

In his teaching on faith found in Romans 4:1-12, the apostle Paul says, “What shall we say about Abraham?” He believed God and it was reckoned to him for righteousness. To one who does not work, but trusts Him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is reckoned as righteousness.

At that time, Abraham was not a circumcised Jew so he was reckoned as righteous even before he became a child of the (Jewish) covenant. This was so that he might be the Father, not only of the circumcised (Jew), but also of all those who are declared righteous outside the (Jewish) covenant. It is not the keeping of the Law (or any good works) that makes one righteous: it is only by faith . Abraham is therefore considered the father of all those justified by faith . So, even to us who are Gentiles walking by faith, God’s promise based on grace is sure. We shall inherit the earth!

“Therefore God is not ashamed to be called their God; for He has prepared a city for them” (Hebrews 11:16).

How attached to this world are you? Do you find your value in how much of its wealth or fame you can amass? Do you need its popularity and affirmation to give you self-esteem? Or are you one whom Jesus would call the ‘greatest’ in His kingdom?

On one occasion the disciples of Jesus were doing what many of us enjoy. They were having an interesting discussion. One would like to think it was about something important such as eternal security or pre-tribulation rapture , but that would be giving more credit than is due. They were, in

fact, arguing about which of them was the greatest (Mark 9:33-34)! Because of this, Jesus began to teach them what it means to be great in His kingdom, here on earth, and in the city that He has prepared for them.

1. They are to be servants, even slaves (Mark 10:42-45).
2. They must be willing to be last and least (Mark 9:35 and Luke 9:48).
3. They must become humble like a little child (Matt 18:4).
4. They must have the attitude of the younger (Luke 22:26).

This teaching is very contrary to the power structures of this world and, sadly, too much of what we see in church leadership today. Where are the servant leaders, who don't seek prominence or honor for themselves but instead delight to be the last and least when others receive the fame and acclaim? Where are the believers who, like a little child, are transparent, cannot long deceive, hold no grudges, and take no offense? Where are the younger in whom the world has no attachments and little interest in demanding his rights or maintaining his power base?

Where are the people who walk by faith, those of whom He is not ashamed?

Though these people were considered sojourners in this world, they did know three things: 1. They knew that God had made a promise to Abraham.

2. They knew that Jesus would fulfill that promise.
3. They knew that they had a glorious destiny - to dwell in the city of God.

I am reminded of John 13:3 where Jesus, "knowing the Father had given all things into His hands, and that He had come from God and was going to God" then got up and washed His disciples' feet (John 13:1-20)! Being a servant only becomes easy when one knows his standing before God.

Can you look back to a place where God began His work of faith in you as He brought you to the cross? Do you look forward knowing that He will bring you into a glorious destiny He has planned for you?

Are you walking in the faith that leads to that destiny? A walk not in your own power, but by His prompting within you?

Faith demands that we have a vision of God's promises and a desire for His presence.

Summary 1. People of faith will never feel at home in this world. They are pilgrims, and will therefore live accordingly.

2. They never want to return to the ways of the world, its scheming and politics, its methods and prizes, or its pleasures and promises.

3. The King declares that to be great you must have the attitude of the servant, the child, the last, the least, and the younger.

4. As spiritual descendants of Abraham - the father of the children of faith - we have a great destiny. We shall 'inherit the earth.'

5. The great promises of God only come to those who have died to themselves.

6. God is not ashamed of us!

Abraham Tested

“By faith, Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac, and he who had received the promises was ready to offer up his only son, of whom it was said, ‘Through Isaac shall your descendants be named.’ He considered that God was able to raise men, even from the dead; hence speaking figuratively, he did receive him back” (Hebrews 11:17-19).

This time the example is made of Abraham’s obedience when God told him to sacrifice his son, Isaac, in Genesis 22. God spoke and Abraham obeyed. He knew the promises of God regarding his seed and assumed that this promise would be fulfilled through Isaac, but the word had come, and Abraham obeyed. That is faith! He did not understand why God should ask him to do this awful thing; he didn’t question Him. Rather, he simply obeyed.

He knew that what God had promised, God would have to fulfill. If, therefore, God had promised to bless all the nations of the world through the son of promise Isaac, and if he was to put Isaac to death, God would have to do the impossible - raise him back to life.

Paul declares in Romans 4:3 that, “Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him for righteousness.” Then James writes in his book, “Was not Abraham our father justified by works when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar? You see that faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works; and the Scripture was fulfilled that says, ‘Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness’” (James

2:21-23). The apostle continues to say that “faith without works is dead” (James 2:14-16). There is no such thing as faith unless it is made manifest in works!

As with all the other examples of Hebrews 11, here we have a type to teach us truths about God and His purposes in us. Here, once again, are clear teachings regarding the Resurrection and God’s faithfulness. God has made a promise and is able to fulfill it; however, there are other truths to be gleaned from these verses.

There will come times when God will test His people. He doesn’t do this so that He might learn something from the results for He knows the outcome even before the testing, nor does He test us by allowing temptations to come. That is the work of Satan using our own carnal desires to lead us astray.

Indeed, Jesus taught His disciples to pray , “Father, lead us not into temptation” (Luke 11:4) knowing that is never in the will of God. However, testing is. For it is by testing us that He purifies us and conforms us more and more to the image of His son, Jesus.

When metallic ore is processed in order to produce the pure metal, it undergoes severe testing in the furnace and pressing mills. The ore is heated until it is all melted, and the dross is skimmed away. When no impurities remain, the molten metal glows with a pure light and, when poured out, shows a perfect reflection in its surface. That is why the Lord tests us - so that we might reflect His glory and image.

For many years I was a school teacher in a system that assessed its students using annual exams and periodical tests. Of course, few students liked that system, and so many parents complained that today there is relatively little testing done in schools, and students can often graduate without ever having been examined as to the knowledge or understanding they may have

gained. One of the major complaints against exams is that they always produce failures .

Contrary to popular opinion, I am one who believes that failing can become a valuable stepping stone to success. It enables us to know what our strengths are, where we need to make more effort, and where we could more efficiently direct our energies. In other words, the result of the exam can help us focus more strategically on the pathway ahead of us. When I was in school, I failed some of my public exams. I then chose to focus on subjects in which I had been successful, finally proceeding to an honor's degree in university. No one ever considered me a failure just because I was unable to pass a certain measuring mark in a couple of subjects!

God never counts us as a failure if we do not pass His present testing.

As we wrote in an earlier chapter, one of the tests that the Lord allows to come into a believer's lives is the testing of offenses .

Jesus said that they will surely come, and we had better learn how to deal with them (Luke 17:1).

Another test is that of the closed door. I have experienced the disappointment of God closing a door before me when I had anticipated walking through into a marvelous, new opportunity. The embarrassment was intense as I had spoken freely about this wonderful opportunity God had placed before me, only to find that, when the time came, instead of leading me on, He closed the door. How I wished I had not spoken so freely, because I felt very foolish when it didn't come to pass.

I questioned God of His reasonings and must confess that it took some time before I could yield to His will in this matter.

It was to be another 10 years before I could see just why He closed that door. It was in order to prepare an even better way for me. I tell this story in greater detail in my other book, "Stepping Stones."

A third test we may experience is concerning those things which may hinder us in being led by the Lord.

These would involve our personal strengths, our relationships, and our possessions. Like Abraham, we may be asked to give up what is most precious to us. God doesn't do this to hurt us - that is never His intention. He does it to set us free from any trust we may have in our own abilities.

So often we will find that when we lay down our possessions before Him, He invites us to take them back up to use them in service for Him. I think of my friend, Rob, who was the lead singer in a rock and roll band when He came to the Lord. His conversion was very real, and he soon found that singing in the night clubs was unsatisfying. He lay aside his guitar, since the only music he knew how to play was unsuitable for the new songs he wanted to sing. It was four years before he believed that the Lord would have him take up the instrument again, at which time he began to sing new songs. Today, Rob is in a full-time music ministry for the Lord.

Moses had to lay down his shepherd's staff - a sign of his occupation and authority (Exodus 4:3), then he was instructed to take it up again, but this time it was called the "rod of God" with which he was to do mighty deeds such as open a way across the Red Sea (Exodus 4:17).

Gideon had to give up his army so that God might win a great victory over the Midianites (Judges 7).

We may be called to give up relationships, family, or our home. Let me remind you of the promise of Jesus, that "Truly, I say to you, there is no one who has left house or wife or brothers[b] or parents or children, for the sake of the kingdom of God, who will not receive many times more in this time, and in the age to come eternal life" (Luke 18:29-30).

Whenever I read the story of Abraham and Isaac, I feel something of the pain in the father's heart. What an agonizing time it must have been, as he led his son up the mountain knowing the intentions in his head. He still

clung to the hope that God would somehow change the outcome, even speaking prophetically that “God would provide Himself the lamb for a burnt offering” (Genesis 22:8).

He had no idea how true that would be, for it was on that same mountain, several centuries later, that another father would watch His only begotten Son die as the lamb slain for the sins of the world. How our heavenly Father’s heart must have sorrowed, yet He was determined that His Son would die. This was to be the only way that justice could be met by mercy, so that we might be redeemed from our sinful and lost state.

Summary God was not being cruel or insensitive to the feelings of Abraham when He asked him to sacrifice his only son - the son of promise. He had a great destiny for His servant, but it was necessary to try him in the furnace first. The following principles are revealed in this portion of Hebrews 11: 1. God is faithful in our testing times.

2. When God calls us to lay something down in sacrifice, it is that we might take it up again in power.

3. God only allows testing to come in our lives so that He might make us pure.

4. His plan of redemption is to ‘provide Himself a lamb.’

Isaac and Jacob

“By faith , Isaac invoked future blessings on Jacob and Esau.

By faith , Jacob, when dying, blessed each of the sons of Joseph, bowing in worship over the head of his staff” (Hebrews 11:20-21).

I have brought these two together because they teach us the same principle.

The story of Isaac blessing Jacob and Esau is found in Genesis 27 while that of Jacob blessing the sons of Joseph is in Genesis 48.

There is little to commend Jacob for. He was a deceiver and thief. It was the decision of Esau to sell his birthright for a bowl of soup, but it was the scheming of Jacob, encouraged by his mother, that stole the blessing one expects to be given to the first-born. I’m sure he did not understand the Biblical principal God was going to teach through his deceit. I call it “the principle of the second-born.”

Half a century later, Jacob is involved again as he blesses the two sons of Joseph. Joseph leads his two sons toward his blind father, making sure that the older boy, Manasseh is in front of Jacob’s right hand, the hand of primary blessing. The other son, Ephraim, is on Jacob’s left. The old man however, though outwardly blind, has an inner light directing him to cross his arms and to pronounce the greater blessing on the second born.

For some reason, God is directing the old man to do such an unheard-of thing. Joseph protests, but to no avail. Jacob will obey the inner directive. I

repeat that there is nothing to indicate that he understands why he should cross his arms - this is declared to be done “by faith.”

What is the principle of the second born?

Let us consider those that the Bible records: Cain was the elder, Abel the younger. God honored the latter above the former.

Esau was the elder, Jacob the younger. God said, “Esau I have hated but Jacob I have loved!”

Manasseh was the elder, Ephraim the younger, but Ephraim received the greater blessing.

Adam was the first man created, and Jesus came as ‘the second Adam,’ i.e. the second born.

“For as by a man came death, by a man has come also the resurrection of the dead. For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive” (1 Corinthians 15:21-22).

Even in the days of the Old Testament, God foreshadows the day when His ‘second Adam’ will come to counter the death that has come upon all men because of the disobedience of the first Adam.

He, ‘the son of promise’ will conquer death by his obedience to the directive will of God. He will be the progenitor of a new race of people, those “born twice.” First by water (the natural birth), and second by the Spirit (new birth). It has been truly said that “if you are born once, you will die twice (ie; natural and eternal death), but if you are born twice, you will die but once” (unknown).

The blessings of God are pronounced upon the children of the second born.

Here then is the principle of the new birth without which “it is impossible to see the kingdom of God,” (John 3:3) let alone to enter it. Adam, the first man, is the progenitor of those “born of the flesh” (John 3:6). Jesus, the second man, is the progenitor of those “born of the Spirit” (John 3:6).

For you have been born again not of a perishable seed, but imperishable. that is, through the living and abiding Word of God (1 Peter 1:23).

In an earlier chapter we saw that greatness in the kingdom of Heaven is accredited to those who are as ‘the younger’ (Luke 22:26). So, in the actions of both Isaac and Jacob in blessing the second born, God is again presenting the principle later taught by Jesus. Their actions of ‘faith’ were designed to show us the kind of people we should be as ‘born again.’

Let us look further at the attributes of the second-born or the younger. The younger child has no claim on the inheritance from their earthly father. Their position is of little fame and honor. They are the ‘hand-me-down’ child receiving the clothes and toys discarded by their older sibling.

At school they may be known as “so-and-so’s” sibling, without an identity of their own. Their achievements are measured in comparison to the elder sibling. As the prodigal child, they can leave home with all their earthly possessions in a bag slung over their shoulder, while their older sibling stays to look after their inheritance, the farm.

The younger child is not interested in the status quo, and does not work politically to maintain their possessions. They are a rebel as far as the systems of this world are concerned. I remember when the Living Bible was being produced. Each book of the Bible was published separately, each with a characteristic title.

The Gospel of Mark, concerning Jesus as the servant, was titled, “Jesus - Rebel With a Cause.” His mother proclaimed prophetically, that He would “scatter the proud in the imagination of their hearts, put down the mighty from their thrones, and exalt those of low degree. He would fill the hungry with good things and send the rich away empty” (Magnificat - Luke 1:52-53). That is a declaration of war for the systems of this world! He has come to establish His kingdom, and He calls His people, the twice-born, not to

be satisfied with the society of this world, but to live a counter-culture Christianity.

As I consider other Biblical characters who were noted for being the younger, the least, or the last, I am drawn to the shepherd boy, David.

He was the youngest of eight sons of Jesse (1 Samuel 16). Who could have foreseen such a future for him when the prophet Samuel came to anoint him to be king over Israel? The only experience he had had was tending sheep, but he had not been wasting his time! He had been practicing with the sling, doing his work faithfully, and protecting his father's sheep from the lion and the bear.

Though he was last in the hand-me-down line he never showed resentment. Instead, he learned to accept his position and to wait his turn. The Lord chose him to be king because He knew his heart. To Samuel, God had said, "For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart" (1 Samuel 16:7).

David had learned to trust in God, even when the circumstances seemed like giants before him. He never fastened his gaze on the problems but kept his eyes on the Lord. His confidence was in the Lord and in the sling, not in Saul's armor which he hadn't proved. What have you proved?

God's word? His name? They will stand the test.

When David entered Saul's palace, he would not force God's timetable. He had learned to wait! Do not rush ahead of God; you will only walk in your own shadow! Though there were opportunities when it seemed that God was presenting the throne before him, David still would wait, saying, "I will not lay my hand against the Lord's elect" (1 Samuel 24:6). There was to be no politicking with him. That is the way of the world - it is not the way of the people of the Kingdom, and God knew David's heart!

Summary To the writer of Hebrews 11, the patriarchs Isaac and Jacob were led by God to pronounce blessings on the second born, even through

the deceit of Jacob. The Biblical principles that the Lord would teach us are: 1. Blessed is the person who has been born twice.

2. Our blessings are through the second-born Adam who has redeemed us from the curse of the first-born Adam.

3. Children of the second-born are to be counter-culture Christians, not loving the systems of this world and displaying 'younger' characteristics.

Joseph

“By faith Joseph, at the end of his life, made mention of the exodus of the Israelites and gave directions concerning his burial” (Hebrews 11:22).

The brief account of Joseph’s forgiveness towards the brothers who had treated him so badly is found at the end of Genesis 50. There we find the wonderful statement, “You meant evil against me; but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today” (Genesis 50:20). Though the enemy would often bring about attacks on the people of God, our Father is able to turn them to good, both for us, and for the honor of His name.

It seems surprising that the author of Hebrews did not refer to the valleys and mountains through and over which Yahweh had led Joseph when writing about faith, but instead he chooses what seems to be an insignificant reference closing the first book of the Bible.

“I am about to die, but God will visit you, and bring you up out of this land to the land which He swore to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob” (Genesis 50:24). Then he took an oath of his brothers that when God visited them, they were to take his bones with them to the land that was promised.

It would be another 400 years before this prophecy of Joseph would come to pass under the leadership of Moses. For the fulfillment of his request see Exodus 13: 19 and Joshua 24:32.

Joseph had an inner revelation from God which he confessed with his mouth, much as Peter the apostle would do on Mt.

Hermon over 2000 years later. Therein is his faith.

What can we learn from this verse?

Firstly, we see the similarity between his situation and that of his father and grandfather. Like Isaac and Jacob, he was a stranger, a sojourner in a foreign land. All three men died without having entered into the promise which God had made, the promise of the promised land and of greatness to the nation of Israel. Isaac remained a nomad and a wanderer, Jacob was still in exile in the land of Egypt, and Joseph had reached the giddy heights of prominence, but it was still the greatness of a stranger in a foreign land. Yet to all three, God gave the witness that His promise would not fail. They died in hope not despair.

Whatever our situation in life, we are called to walk the same path as these patriarchs: the walk of faith. We also may rise to prominence in this world, but we must never forget that we are citizens of another, higher kingdom. Most of us will never experience the greater promises of God, but each one of us must live in such a way that we will bring the day nearer when others can rejoice in them. Jesus made a wonderful promise that the Gospel must be preached in the whole world to all nations “and then the end shall come” (Matthew 24:14). He will finally put an end to sin and usher in His kingdom of righteousness.

As you live in the world today, you may believe that His coming is yet a long way off. Nevertheless, the example of Joseph is given to teach us that we are to constantly look forward to the certainty of the fulfillment of the promise and live a life of such expectancy. We are to live each day in the light of eternity.

Over the years Joseph came to know the faithfulness of God, and his language changed. He no longer spoke of dreams in which he would rule over his family. He did not say, “Go and tell my father of all my glory in Egypt.”

The writer of Hebrews has chosen the example of his dying days to teach us something. Joseph is nearing the end of his earthly glory and has realized that all the glories and honors of this world are nothing to a dying man. They may be satisfied for a season, but, in the end they are like a bursting bubble.

Life is a fleeting thing.

“What is your life?” says James, “It is but a vapor that appears for a while and then passes away” (James 4:14).

God stirs faith in the old man so that he now sees where his real inheritance lies. It is in a future land and the coming of a future deliverer. One would think that he would want his descendants to remain in this land of Egypt which has been so good to him. Why then, doesn't he want his body to remain there? Maybe if he wasn't buried in Egypt they would build him a great memorial, a large tomb in a prominent place, or perhaps name a great edifice after him; his name would be known forever. Indeed, he could have a temple built to Yahweh and name it “The First Joseph benJacob Memorial Church.” In that way he could bring honor to God without losing any of his own glory!

However, God will not share His glory with man, nor with any of His creation. I'm being cynical of course but isn't it amazing how many notable 'men of God' in our days, have clung on tenaciously when their honor or reputation is at stake in the battle for integrity and faithfulness to God's work. Isn't it amazing how easily believers can be manipulated to 'do this work' or 'give to that cause,' when there are rewards or prominence associated? Instead, we are called to be as dead men, claiming no rights of our own and seeking no prominence in this world. God has not called us to be famous or successful; He has called us to be faithful.

Like Joseph, our theme should be the coming of our deliverer and our gathering together to Him. Jesus is our deliverer, and He is coming soon.

He has already delivered us from the penalty of sin - justification, wholeness for our spirits. He is presently delivering us from the power of sin - sanctification, wholeness for our souls, and He will soon come to deliver us from the presence of sin - glorification, wholeness for our bodies!

I am convinced that, unlike Joseph, we do not have to wait over 400 years, but that “soon and very soon, we are going to see the King” (Andraé Crouch, *Soon and Very Soon*). As I look at this world with its growing problems of overpopulation, famines, natural disasters, and the breaking down of families and social structures. As I look at the church with its great expansion and missions programs in most parts of the world I am convinced He is coming soon. As I consider the polarization within the church between those faithful to His Word and its more liberal members, I am not dismayed, but recognize that He is now preparing and purifying His bride. If we are alive when He comes, we shall go to that inheritance, but if we fall asleep, we shall not be left behind. So, in Joseph’s words uttered by faith, we see the living and the dead going together from the place of bondage.

“The dead in Christ shall rise first. Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so shall we ever be with the Lord” (1 Thessalonians 4:16-17).

Surely the glory and tinsel of this world fades as we look forward to that glad day, so soon to take place. Are we making this our daily theme? Maybe we need to come again to our ‘deathbed’ at the foot of the cross where our vision will be changed, because dead men do not have regard for the things of this world.

Summary On his deathbed, Joseph was given the faith to look into the future and see the deliverer, Moses, who would come to lead God’s people out of Egypt and take them to their inheritance.

Though he was a successful man in Egypt, faith revealed that there was a better land and a better future for the children of Israel.

1. A deliverer, Jesus, has come to take us from our bondage and lead us to His promised kingdom.

2. Faith causes us to look forward with the eyes of men who are dead to this world.

3. Our destiny is not found in our possessions or position - it is found in His promise.

4. We need to live each day in the light of His second coming.

5. This life is but a fleeting moment.

Moses

“By faith Moses, when he was born, was hidden for three months by his parents, because they saw that the child was beautiful, and they were not afraid of the king's edict. By faith Moses, when he was grown up, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter, choosing rather to be mistreated with the people of God than to enjoy the fleeting pleasures of sin. He considered the reproach of Christ greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt, for he was looking to the reward.

By faith he left Egypt, not being afraid of the anger of the king, for he endured as seeing him who is invisible. By faith he kept the Passover and sprinkled the blood, so that the Destroyer of the firstborn might not touch them. By faith the people crossed the Red Sea as on dry land, but the Egyptians, when they attempted to do the same, were drowned (Hebrews 11:23-29).

Here begins a summary of the life of Moses, the friend of God.

The full story covered by the brief Scripture above is found in Exodus 2-14.

After his birth in Egypt, the Pharaoh reigning over that land issued an edict that all male infants must be put to death, being afraid that the Jews might one day become too numerous and would rise up in power against Egypt. The midwives, however, feared God, so they did not do as Pharaoh commanded. God blessed them for this action and the Jewish people grew very strong.

One Hebrew family having a young son hid him in the bulrushes by faith until the time when God revealed the hidden child to a daughter of Pharaoh (Exodus 1-2). It was God who led this Levite and his wife to hide their child in the place where God would ordain; he would be found by the princess.

Their faith is revealed in the way that they obeyed this inner compulsion.

When Moses had grown up, he was led by God to become a shepherd in the land of Midian (Hebrews 11:27). There he remained until the age of eighty, tending sheep for his father-in-law, Jethro (Exodus 2:11-3:1). The natural account of events tells us that Moses fled in fear from Pharaoh because he had killed a man! Though brought up in Pharaoh's home, he had been taught by Hebrew servants - his own mother among them - and knew himself to be a child of the Hebrew people. He felt an inner drawing to the people of his birth even though he was surrounded by the trappings and riches of Egypt. Such longing erupted into the violence of murder, and the loneliness of flight.

I do not believe the Scriptures to be contradictory so we must read the account in Hebrews 11 as expressing God's leading in Moses' life so that he would not experience the wrath of Pharaoh. 'Being afraid,' meaning the experience of Pharaoh's wrath.

The writer to the Hebrews is looking at the events in retrospect and he can see, in all the events of Moses' life, the clear hand of God leading. He is preparing a man for a mission .

Subsequent history shows why God took him from Pharaoh's household, though the causative act was Moses' own violence.

"What a waste of a life!" we might say as we watch this man, trained in the household of Pharaoh, skilled to hold his own in any company of the

elite. Instead, we find him working as a shepherd, tending sheep. This he did for 40 ‘wasted’ years!

But nothing is wasted when God is in control. What better training could there be for the mission God was arranging?!

He wanted a man, who knew the ways of the courts of Pharaoh and who could lead millions of bleating, two-legged sheep for forty years in the wilderness!

Every change of direction in Moses’ life had been ordained by God; He was preparing a special man for a special purpose, and He had chosen the right man, for He knew this man’s heart and that he could be trusted to follow His leading by faith .

First, however, there had to be the burning bush (Exodus 3:2), where God had great difficulty in persuading His servant to have more confidence in His ability and leading (Exodus 3:11, 4:1, 10, 13 and more). Note Exodus 4:14, God was angry because of Moses’ lack of ‘belief’!

In verse 28 Moses obeyed when he was instructed to celebrate the Passover by sprinkling blood on the doorposts of each Hebrew home in Egypt (Exodus 12). He could have questioned God on this ridiculous command, but he didn’t.

This is faith.

Now in verse 29 he begins to show more confidence and trust in God (Exodus 14:13), but the emphasis of the verse is that God opened the sea and caused the Egyptians to drown, not because Moses had ‘believed’ it into being. He just obeyed when told what to do, after crying to God in his despair. He put his rod into the waters of the Red Sea so that the waters parted and the Hebrews could cross on dry land (Exodus 14).

He could have questioned God on this ridiculous command, but he didn’t. This is faith.

No wonder Moses was called “the friend of God” (Exodus 33:11). His whole life is an example of the walk of faith.

What principle can we learn from the example of Moses?

Surely, that the Lord is walking before His people when they are walking in faith. He directs them so that He might use them for the praise of His glory. He will bring them to the place of destiny He has planned for them. Sometimes He leads through valley experiences, sometimes His ways are uncomfortable and without reason, but He knows the way that we take.

“When God wants to drill a man and thrill a man and skill a man; When God wants to mold a man to play the noblest part; When He yearns with all His heart to create so great and bold a man that all the world shall be amazed, Watch His methods! Watch His ways!

How He ruthlessly perfects - those He royally elects; How He hammers him and hurts him and with mighty blows converts him into trial lumps of clay which only God can understand!

While his tortured heart is crying and he lifts beseeching hands!

How He bends, but never breaks those whose good He undertakes; How He uses those He chooses and with loving purpose fuses, his burdened soul induces him to try God’s riches out.

God knows what He’s about!”

(Author unknown) The Two Rocks The one act recorded in the life of Moses where he was not obedient to the Divine command is found in Numbers 20. This act of disobedience cost him his greatest desire - to enter the promised land. It is worth considering this in more detail, since at first glance it seems to be a very petty act by a God who calls Himself, Moses’ friend!

In Exodus 17, shortly after the Israelites had left Egypt, they began to complain that they did not have sufficient water to drink. God said to Moses, “Behold, I will stand before you there on the rock at Horeb, and

you shall strike the rock, and water shall come out of it, and the people will drink” (Exodus 17:6). Moses obeyed and the people were able to drink.

Nearly forty years later at the entrance to Canaan, a similar event occurs with embarrassing and painful results for Moses.

In Numbers 20, the people are complaining again that they have no water. God’s instructions to Moses this time are that he “Take the staff, and assemble the congregation, you and Aaron your brother, and tell the rock before their eyes to yield its water” (Numbers 20:8). Instead, Moses first chastised the people for their grumbling and then, turning to the rock, smote it with the rod. No water came out! In his embarrassment, he smote it again and God showed grace in allowing the water to flow; however, this act of disobedience caused Him to declare, “Because you did not believe in me, to uphold me as holy in the eyes of the people of Israel, therefore you shall not bring this assembly into the land that I have given them” (Numbers 20:12). Though Moses would plead with God that he might be forgiven and have the thrill of entering Canaan, it was not to be (Deuteronomy 3:23-26).

Some would say that Moses was judged because he lost his temper with the people. I do not believe so. God is far bigger than to judge his friend for that! It is only as we study a little deeper that we discover the wonderful truth the Lord wanted Moses to portray to us - a picture he marred by his disobedience.

We need to consider the two rocks and the two rods in the references above. In the Exodus reference, the Hebrew word for rock is “ tsoor ,” which is a sharp or cutting stone. It was as a rock of flint, a small piece of which could be sharpened to be a knife. Such a stone would be used to kill and divide the sacrificial animals. When God made His covenant with Abraham, it was by cutting animals in two, setting them apart so that a divine flaming torch passed between them (Genesis 15). Even today, when some African tribes make a tribal agreement, they use the expression “cut-

ting a covenant.” The picture of Exodus 17 is of God standing at the place of the sharp stone bearing the beating of the rod of Moses on His body.

What an interesting foreshadow to the day when our Saviour God would cut an eternal covenant for us by bearing the beating of the Law in His own body on Calvary’s tree! The water of life flowed from that broken body; water that causes those who drink “to never thirst again” (John 4:14).

In the Numbers reference, the Hebrew word for rock is “selah,” which is a fortress, a high cliff, or a stronghold. The rod is to be Aaron’s rod - the rod of the High Priest. The type this time is of a Saviour, high and lifted up, to whom we come with the authority of priests. We speak to the rock in prayer and intercession, thanksgiving and worship, and water flows.

It was this picture that Moses failed to present by his disobedience.

Peter the apostle wrote, “For Christ died for our sins once for all, the just for the unjust... [and now He is] at the right hand of God, having gone into heaven, angels and all authorities being subject to Him” (1 Peter 3:18,22).

Praise God that the work of the cross is a complete work. Jesus does not need to be put to death again. Now He reigns on high and we come to Him with uplifted eyes, to worship as kings and priests before our God - and He continues to pour out His living water.

We should note in passing that Moses did enter the Promised Land, not in the life of flesh but in the glorified life of God’s friend (Mark 9). The end of the journey for all who walk in faith, is that they shall be with their Saviour, glorified in His presence. Though the Lord might chastise us, it is only for a season in order that He might mold us to be His image. The future glory is sure for all condemnation and judgment has been passed from us to the Saviour!

Summary It is in the life of Moses that I see the clearest example of a life of faith. Throughout his life God had directed the circumstances that

would mold a man after His own heart and for His own purposes. This truly is a man who would be “to the praise of His glory” (Ephesians 1:12).

1. All things work together for good to them that are walking by faith.
2. Friends of God are those who walk by faith.
3. God is looking for men and women He can mold into vessels of His glory.
4. The process of molding is the work of faith.
5. Faith does not deliver us from the chisel or hammer of the Divine sculptor.

Rahab

“By faith the walls of Jericho fell down after they had been encircled for seven days. By faith Rahab the prostitute did not perish with those who were disobedient, because she had given a friendly welcome to the spies” (Hebrews 11:30).

The story of Jericho and Rahab is found in Joshua 2, 3, and 6:22f.

Jericho was the first fortified city that the Israelites came upon once they had crossed the Jordan River into Canaan. How were they to conquer this city seeing that they had no weapons of warfare? Joshua, the new leader of God’s people, sends two spies to consider this problem. They enter the house of Rahab which was evidently set upon the wall of the city. She is recorded to be a harlot, though some commentators suggest that this means nothing more than that she ran a boarding house.

The people of Jericho were well aware of the approaching Israelites and had heard stories of the amazing things that their god had done for them, so when two strangers came to town, it was a natural assumption that they were spies.

Rahab decides to deceive her people, hiding the spies from their searching, and telling the enquirers that the two men had left the city soon after their arrival. We do not commend her for her deceit and lies, but history is to show that God had a destiny for Rahab far above anything she may have deserved.

The spies return to Joshua with the encouraging news that the city inhabitants are full of fear and that “the Lord has given all the land into our hands” (Joshua 2:24).

Joshua gives his people what seems to be some ridiculous instructions, but he has heard them from God and therefore must obey. They are to march around the city once a day for six days and then seven times on the seventh day! The people could have questioned him, they could have argued, but by now they were becoming more aware of the ways of God.

Faith is not opposed to reason; it is above reason. On the seventh day, after circling the city seven times, the priests blew trumpets, the people shouted, and the walls fell down!

Was it the great belief of Joshua that did this? It is striking that his name isn’t even mentioned in Hebrews! If our author had wanted to point out Joshua’s great belief in God, he could have used the example of Joshua and Caleb returning from spying out the land in Numbers 14. Their ten fellow spies were full of fear and would not venture further, causing Caleb and Joshua to become angry with them, declaring, “The Lord is with us; fear them not!” (Numbers 14:9). They believed in God, but the writer to the Hebrews is not trying to show us their great trust, but rather, God’s actions by faith .

Faith does not need a man to understand and believe; it needs anyone who will obey, even when he does not understand or believe! “O Lord, I believe; help Thou, my unbelief!” (Mark 9:24). It requires one to be obedient to God’s word. Obedience was evident and the walls fell down, by faith . God had spoken, the people had obeyed, and God pushed the walls down. If He had told them to speak to the mountain and they had obeyed, He would have moved the mountain.

What a strange example of faith Rahab seems to be at first glance! Here is a woman who is a liar, a deceiver, and a traitor to her own people, yet

both the writer to the Hebrews and the apostle James record her as an example of faith. Where then, is her faith revealed? It was by faith that she did not perish.

God kept her alive because of her response to His witness within her. She said to the spies hidden on her rooftop, “I know that the LORD has given you the land, and that the fear of you has fallen upon us, and that all the inhabitants of the land melt away before you... And as soon as we heard it, our hearts melted, and there was no spirit left in any man because of you, for the LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath” (Joshua 2:9,11).

All her neighbors believed the same as she did, but they still clung to their empty hope that somehow they could deflect the judgment of God from themselves. They believed that their gods still had some power to stand against Him. Unlike her, they would not confess what they knew to be true, for theirs was a knowledge of the head based on the stories and rumors they had heard, whereas hers was a knowledge of the heart much like Peter’s when he declared on Mount Hermon, “Thou art the Christ!” (Joshua 2:11). She had a conviction and a confession.

How wrong the people of Jericho were! Just like the multitudes today who believe that the Lord won’t carry out His stated intention to judge this world for its sin and refusal to accept His (only) means of escape - the salvation found at the cross of Jesus.

In the story of Rahab, God paints another picture of that cross, in requiring Rahab to hang a crimson thread from her window so that the attacking armies will recognize it as her guarantee of deliverance. The crimson thread has always been our means of deliverance; that stream of blood which still flows from the wounds of Calvary.

When the walls fell, Rahab and her family were delivered as she had been promised, because she trusted that the thread in her window would be

honored. Similarly, God is committed to honor all those who come to Him by way of the blood. There is no other way! “Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life; whoever does not obey the Son shall not see life, but the wrath of God remains on him” (John 3:36). “Knowing that you were ransomed... not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot” (1 Peter 1:18-19).

Rahab was an idolator, brought up to worship other gods. The light she had might not have been very great, her advantages had been few, but she followed the gleam of that inner light.

She actively believed, and was delivered; this is the true principle of faith.

In Matthew 1, we find the genealogy of Jesus, the son of David, the son of Abraham. The apostle’s purpose is to show his Jewish readers the great and royal heritage from which Jesus has come. He is fully a Jew, as son of Abraham; he is fully a king by male descent, as son of David, but notice the name honored in verse five. Rahab the harlot, delivered by faith, is the great great grandmother of king David! She is recorded as a direct ancestor of the Saviour!!

My daughter Corinne is very involved in tracing our family tree. This was very interesting to me at first, but as she began to dig deeper, I became a little anxious.

I had been reading a “Time Life” book on the “Pirates of the Caribbean” in the eighteenth century and was startled to find that some of the most notorious were Welshmen, like myself!

I dreaded the day when Corinne would announce, with a smug look on her face, that one of my ancestors was an infamous pirate.

When the Holy Spirit directed the apostles to write the Gospel, He did not hide from our view that Jesus was descended from harlots, deceivers,

murderers, and womanizers. Indeed, His mother Mary could not have found it easy bearing the suspicious looks of her neighbors when it became evident she was with child outside of wedlock! Nothing is told us of her parents, the grandparents of the Saviour. Could that be because they found it very difficult to accept the shame such a pregnancy would bring upon them? After all, how could they be expected to believe that their daughter was still a virgin when it was evident she was pregnant?!

If I had been God, I would have done it differently! I would have had my son born in the finest hospital in Jerusalem tended by the finest doctors. I would have chosen a royal princess, the most beautiful, talented, educated woman in the world to be his mother and I would have surrounded him with wealth and glory that he was accustomed to. I would announce to all the world by a voice like thunder from heaven, that my son had been born.

Instead, God chose that Jesus should be born in a barn, a dirty smelly place occupied by cattle. His father would be embarrassed and his mother lonely, rejected by her friends, and possibly her family too, with the taunts of ‘harlot’ in her ears. His announcement was heard only by some humble shepherds tending their sheep. God’s public relations man really blew it, didn’t he!

Here is love! There is no way that Jesus would draw men to follow Him because of His status, wealth, or pedigree. He will not allow these things to rob you of your right to choose. The only thing He requires of you is your love, and that cannot be forced from you. He will not manipulate you to follow Him.

The mighty men of this world have their followers who hang on because of the status it gives them. When a new president is elected, we watch the news with interest to see those who he will gather around him. Jesus offers His followers nothing of this world’s wealth and power. Instead, He identifies Himself with the lowest of people so that all may feel they can

draw close to Him. Are you misunderstood, rejected, beaten down, or accused? He can empathize because He was treated the same way. Are you poor, of little esteem, having little of which to boast? He understands, for He has walked that same road.

Napoleon Bonaparte is reputed to have said, "At the age of thirty-three Alexander the Great conquered the known world.

At the same age, I have conquered the known world. We both conquered by the power of the sword. At thirty-three years of age Jesus also conquered the whole world, but He conquered by the power of love - and He has conquered me!"

God chose a harlot, by faith, knowing that, from her would come the Saviour of the World; His own precious Son, Jesus.

This is grace! Unmerited love!

Summary Both the writer to the Hebrews and James gave Rahab as an example of faith at work.

As the Israelites drew near to Jericho, God was working out His purposes. He would pick out a woman who was to become an antecedent of Jesus, a harlot from a heathen people. Little did she know her destiny when she hid the spies!

We should learn the following principles: 1. Joshua believed God and obeyed. He is not even named in our verse because faith does not bring honor to man; its purpose is to bring honor to God.

2. Rahab's conviction became a confession.

3. God's promises to us are contingent on the application of the crimson thread (the blood).

4. God has a mighty destiny for all who walk by faith.

5. Grace reaches to the lowest and raises them to the heights of royalty.

What More Shall I Say?

“And what more shall I say? For time would fail me to tell of Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the prophets - who through faith conquered kingdoms, enforced justice, obtained promises, stopped the mouths of lions, quenched the power of fire, escaped the edge of the sword, were made strong out of weakness, became mighty in war, put foreign armies to flight.

Women received back their dead by resurrection. Some were tortured, refusing to accept release, so that they might rise again to a better life. Others suffered mocking and flogging, and even chains and imprisonment. They were stoned, they were sawn in two, they were killed with the sword. They went about in skins of sheep and goats, destitute, afflicted, mistreated - of whom the world was not worthy - wandering about in deserts and mountains, and in dens and caves of the earth. And all these, though commended through their faith, did not receive what was promised, since God had provided something better for us, that apart from us they should not be made perfect” (Hebrews 11:32-40).

The nine verses that end the chapter clearly bear out my premise. By faith, many did great deeds and saw great miracles; by faith, others were put through great pain and anguish. Surely this wasn't because they believed, but because it was God's good intention that even through suffering He would be glorified in His people. They were willing because they had an inner witness of reality that would not let them escape the sorrow and pain.

They could have done so, if they had denied their Lord as their persecutors demanded.

The sacred writer has made their point in the previous examples of this chapter. Now he just groups a lot of names together, not even in chronological order, but that will not bother his readers for they are well aware of the histories of each new name recorded. We might lose the impact of these names and deeds as they are fired at us so quickly, but to the Jews, each phrase would bring a vivid memory.

Josephus, an early historian, used the same Greek phrase as our author when describing how David ‘conquered kingdoms.’

The Septuagint - the Greek version of our Old Testament - uses the same words to tell how David ‘wrought righteousness,’ how faith ‘stopped the mouths of lions’ for Daniel, and how faith ‘quenched raging fires’ for Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.

The reference to ‘escaping the edge of the sword’ would turn the readers’ thoughts to the deliverance of Elija and Elisha from Jezebel and the Syrians. Further examples are taken from the lives of the faithful not recorded in our Old Testament, but probably well known to readers of the apocryphal books, especially the second book of Maccabees. Certainly, the phrases ‘being mighty in war’ and ‘putting alien armies to flight’ would immediately cause them to think of the unforgettable glories of Maccabean days.

However, the stories of faith are not always victorious when seen through mortal eyes. If the chapter stopped at verse 34, we would be tempted to believe that only good things happen to those who have faith in God: health, wealth and prosperity, but rather, death, persecution and suffering. Can this be by faith? Yes! Yes! Yes! If God will be glorified in it, yes! And He has been glorified through the suffering of His people.

As I read the Gospel of John, I find many times that Jesus speaks about His coming glory. What do you think of when you read the word, “glory?” I have tried to define it and finally concluded it to be the fullness of God, revealed. Jesus said in John 17:1, “Father, the hour is come; glorify Thy Son, that the Son may glorify You” and He went to the cross. Indeed, every reference to glory in John’s gospel is associated with the death of Jesus! Glory comes through suffering!

Maccabean history was full of records of the suffering and martyrdom of faithful Jewish people during the evil days of the Syrian, Antiochus Epiphanes. Stories which Hebrew readers could well relate to the phrases above, and the history of the church since the times of the apostles and the writer of Hebrews, has many similar accounts.

We could write, “ By faith Stephen was put to death, crying, ‘Father, do not lay this sin to his charge!’” By this act of faith, he released Saul of Tarsus from the condemnation of God , thereby opening the way for God to call Saul into his great ministry as Paul the Apostle. If Stephen had reacted to his anguish by calling God’s wrath down on Saul (as I confess, I would have been tempted to do!), I wonder if Saul would ever have become the great apostle.

By faith Paul was imprisoned in Rome so that he would have the time to write the great epistles which have become such a source of encouragement and guidance for countless believers.

By faith the early believers were persecuted so that the gospel would spread throughout the Roman world as they fled their persecutors.

By faith, Cranmer, Ridley, and Latimer were burned at the stake in the middle of the sixteenth century so that a “light might be lit in England that would never be put out” (Hugh Latimer).

By faith the missionaries were ordered out of China in the middle of the twentieth century so that a pure church of believers might grow within the

Chinese culture - not an imitation of the western church. That's a hard one for many of us who have the contorted view that only the western concept of church is acceptable to God. In my travels I have almost come to the cynical position that our 'western' church is the least acceptable to God!

Some will not accept that the church in China has grown to multiplied millions since the missionaries left. Let me add here, lest I am misunderstood, that I strongly believe in missions and missionaries. Sometimes, however, I find our methods and lack of unity hard to accept. Thank the Lord, this is becoming less evident in recent missions' history.

By faith five young American men died in the jungles of Ecuador on January 8th, 1956 so that the Auca Indians might also become inheritors with us of the riches of the Gospel. The world's editorials called this a great waste of young American lives, but as one of them, Jim Elliott, had written in his diary just hours before his death, "He is no fool who gives up what he cannot keep, to gain what he cannot lose!" (Jim Elliot). That should become the motto of all who would walk by faith.

The names of Pete Fleming, Roger Youderian, Ed McCully, Nate Saint, and Jim Elliott, together with their wives', are well known in both Heaven and in Hell. For through the death and anguish they suffered, a wide breach was made in the prison walls that had kept the Auca Indians in the captivity of sin.

Today, we can rejoice that many thousands of those precious people have walked through into the freedom found only in Christ.

Should my reader not know of this event, I encourage you to read, "Through Gates of Splendour" by Elizabeth Elliott, Jim's widow.

Truly we can concur with the statement that the death of martyrs has been the life-blood of the church. Today, in the twentieth century, there is possibly more martyrdom and more persecution than at any time in histo-

ry, but the church is not defeated and continues to grow at an exponential rate.

Some through the waters, some through the flood, Some through the fire, but all through the blood; Some through great sorrow but God gives a song, in the night season and all the day long.

(G.A.Young) Might we not also write that by faith, (your name) went into the latest valley of pain because the Father wants to make them more like His other child, Jesus?

“And all these, though commended through their faith, did not receive what was promised, since God had provided something better for us, that apart from us they should not be made perfect” (Hebrews 11:39-40).

All these men and women of faith are recorded as an example to us. They did not receive any reward in this life for their faithfulness. They had faith in God. They trusted Him and obeyed the word He spoke to them and within them; however, they had not received the ‘something better’ that is ours today.

The reward for their faithfulness is found in the Saviour, Christ, who will give to every man as he deserves - not for his greatness in the eyes of the world or the church, but for his faith. Further, we have been given the indwelling Holy Spirit which is the promise of the Father (Acts 1:4), “Christ in us, the hope of glory” who will lead us into truth. It is His inner witness that enables us to walk in faith as we yield to His inner revelation. It is He who has brought us into saving faith, and He will produce the fruit of faith in us as we stand by the streams of living water. As we drink deeply of the rivers of living water, we shall produce fruit in due season.

Oh Lord, I long to walk in your will. As the deer pants for the waters so my heart longs after you. Lead me in your will. I do not ask to know your will nor to be happy in it. Should you lead me through deep valleys I am willing to go, for you shall be my comforter even in the valley of the shadow

of death. I know how foolish and stubborn I can be so whenever I step out of your will, I give you full permission to whip me back into line. All I ask is that at the end of this journey, I will hear you say, “well done my good and faithful servant!”

The picture I have of faith is that I am merely a child holding on to my heavenly Father’s hand.

I do not know if today He will take me to places of pleasure such as the ‘sweetshop’ of life, or instead to the pain of the ‘dentist.’ I do know that He will find it necessary to take me to the latter if I go often to the former!

I do not know if tomorrow He will lead me into a deep valley, but I do know that, in my past, such valleys have always been there before He takes me to mountain tops with Himself.

I do not know what His will is for me (other than what Scripture reveals for all of us), but I do know that He knows the path ahead.

I do not know what tomorrow holds, but I do know who holds tomorrow, and He is holding my hand!

“I want my life to be all filled with praise to Thee, My precious Lord divine Who died for me.

Let all my will be Thine, controlled by love divine, Live out in me Thy life, O mighty Saviour.

Chorus: Thy precious will divine, with joy I make it mine, My heart shall be Thy throne, and Thine alone.

Choose thou the path I tread, and whither I am led, Help me to follow on, O mighty Saviour.

A pilgrim born anew, a stranger going through, Not of this world am I since I am Thine.

Weaned from its passing show, transformed Thy love to know, Hold thou my hand in Thine, O mighty Saviour.

When evil foes assail and almost would prevail, In that dark hour be
Thou my strength and shield.

Lend then Thy strong embrace, uphold me by Thy grace, In weakness
be my strength, O mighty Saviour.

Yea, choose the path for me, although I may not see, The reason Thou
dost will to lead me so.

I know the toilsome way will lead to realms of day, Where I shall dwell
with Thee, O mighty Saviour.”

(H.Tee) - permission sought.

THE END

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